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THE RISING NEPAL

ALL BE HAPPY, ALL BE WELL

PRESIDENT PAUDEL EXPRESSES CONCERN OVER DESERTED VILLAGES

BY AMAR RAJ NAHARKI
Tanahun, Jan. 5

President Ramchandra Paudel has expressed his concern about Nepal's rapidly emptying villages.

Addressing a programme organised by the Purkot Secondary School in Tanahun to celebrate its centennial on Friday, President Paudel thought that, despite the availability of infrastructure and facilities, a lack of dignified employment was forcing people out of the rural areas.

"The villages today have everything except respectable employment and income opportunities," he lamented, mentioning that the nation was facing an exodus of talent and labour. "This is one of the most complicated challenges facing the country."

The President called on one and all to develop a culture of respecting work and stressed the need for Nepalis to recognise their nation. "We have very fertile soil, clean air and water, and immense biodiversity. But we have failed to understand them and have engaged ourselves with hollow slogans," he said, asking people to farm according to the climate, showcase our culture to promote tourism and create jobs and use our hydroelectricity to earn money.

"No need to leave your family and wander abroad. No need to go around looking for the musk we ourselves carry," he suggested. "Let us understand ourselves. Let us be village-oriented and Nepal-oriented. Let us teach these in schools. This is real nationalism."

Recalling the pledge he made to bring modern services to the villages and make people want to live in rural communities when he contested his first election in 1991, he said that many settlements across the country had received roads, electricity, drinking water, education, health and communication facilities. "Yet, people continue to leave," he worried.

Paudel, who came to his home district Tanahun for the second time after becoming the President, recalled that he had stood on the Chhipchhipe Hill and the banks of the Madi, Seti and Kali rivers and determined agriculture, tourism and energy to be the pillars of national development. But, for this, the first requirement is good governance.

"I am still firm on this agenda," he stated.

Meanwhile, RSS adds: President Ramchandra Paudel has stressed the need to develop Jitgadhi as a tourism hub of greater Butwal.

He emphasized on connecting the areas of historical, archeological, religious and cultural importance around Jitgadhi in a circuit as it is an important historical center of Nepali bravery.

At a programme organised by the Nepal Army to hand over the historical Jitgadhi fort located at Butwal submetropolis-1 on Friday, President Paudel said Jitgahdi could contribute to the country's tourism development if it was connected with Sahasradhara, Laxminagar and Hitpark through the Palace of Manimukundasen, Nuwakotgadhi and Ramapithekash area.

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PHOTO: RSS
Tharu dancers of Gadhawa Rural Municipality-7 of Dang district performing Sakhiya dance at Magh Cultrural Festival -2080 in Ghorahi On Friday.

National interest on top priority in any agreement: PM

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 5



Prime Minister Prachanda

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has said that his government cannot even imagine making an agreement that goes against the national interest.

He said this at the meeting of the State Affairs and Good Governance Committee of the House of Representatives on Friday during discussions on the bill made to amend the Constitutional Council (Functions, Duties, Powers and Procedures) Act, 2010. Lawmakers had asked him about the agreements signed during Indian External Affairs Minister Dr. S. Jaishankar's Nepal visit.

At the committee, Prime Minister Prachanda said, "Yesterday, I met with the External Affairs Minister of India one-on-one and as part of the larger Nepali delegation. On both occasions, I talked about power trade and other issues of national interest."

Clarifying the agreement to allow India to directly fund projects up to Rs. 200 million, the Prime Minister said that Nepal would have a role in the decision-making process. "India cannot decide alone. Nepal will be a partner in the process."

He added, "The main thing is that India will buy 10,000 megawatts of electricity in 10 years regardless of who produces it. Let there be no illusions. The agreement signed will be implemented in line with Nepal's interests."

Speaking about the visit by Shi Yugang, deputy general secretary of the Chinese Communist Party of Yunnan Province and Jaiskhankar's supposed displeasure at having his trip coincide with Yugang's, Prime Minister Prachanda said that the Indian Minister had not uttered even a single word about it in any of the meetings. "Statements [of his dissatisfaction] are just rumours. There is no truth in them," he stressed.

Regarding the bill discussed, Prime Minister Prachanda said that the amendment bill would address the irregularities and problems seen in constitutional appointments in the past.

Indian Foreign Minister returns home

Foreign Ministers of Nepal and India inaugurate India-assisted projects

BY MODNATH DHAKAL
Kathmandu, Jan. 5

Minister for External Affairs of India, Dr. Subrahmanyam Jaishankar returned to New Delhi on Friday after concluding his two-day Nepal visit.

He was seen off by Minister for Foreign Affairs of N.P. Saud and Foreign Secretary Sewa Lamsal at the Tribhuvan International Airport.

Before leaving for India, Dr. Jaishankar visited Pashupatinath temple and offered worship in the morning.

Likewise, Minister for Foreign Affairs of Nepal, N.P. Saud, and Minister for External Affairs of India, Dr. Subrahmanyam Jaishankar, jointly inaugurated Tribhuvan University Central Library building, constructed with the Government of India's grant assistance, on Friday morning, informed the Ministry of Foreign Affairs.

Likewise, the two Ministers also virtually inaugurated 58 post earthquake reconstruction projects, including educational institutions, health facilities and cultural heritages, completed under the Indian assistance, informed the Ministry of Foreign Affairs (MoFA) through X.



PHOTO: SUJAN GURUNG/TRN
Indian Minister for External Affairs S. Jaishankar returning home after completing two-day official visit to Nepal on Friday.

Indian External Minister, Dr. Jaishankar was on a two-day official visit of Nepal to participate in the seventh meeting of the Nepal India Joint Commission, the high level mechanism between the two countries that reviews the overall relations between them.

Earlier on Thursday, the Joint Commission Meeting deliberated upon various bilateral issues and signed some agreements in presence of the foreign ministers of Nepal and India, Saud and Dr. Jaishankar, who co-chaired the meeting.

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Leaders should unite for Karnali's development: DPM Khadka

BY NABIN SUBEDI
Surkhet, Jan. 5



Deputy Prime Minister and Minister for Defence Purna Bahadur Khadka has said that all the political parties should unite to develop Karnali Province.

Inaugurating the 34th National Volleyball competition in Birendragnagar of Surkhet on Friday, DPM Khadka said that the leaders and lawmakers of the province should be more responsible for the development of Karnali Province.

"We are the ones who should develop and give a facelift to Karnali by forging unity among the political parties," DPM Khadka said.

"No dispute should be among the leaders of all politics regarding progress, achievements, and infrastructure development of the Karnali," he added.

In the context of sports development, DPM Khadka said that all should unite in one forum to successfully conclude the upcoming 10th National Games scheduled from November 17 to 24, 2024 in Karnali.

The federal government is active and positive in managing sufficient budget for constructing the infrastructure for the national games, he said.

Karnali Province Minister for Social Development Khadka Bahadur Pokhrel said that the province government had asked the federal government to arrange the required budget for developing sports infrastructure before the commencement of the national games.

"The provincial government alone cannot construct infrastructure in its budget for conducting all kinds of games here," said Minister Pokhrel.

Parliamentary leader of the Karnali Province of the CPN-UML and former minister Yam Lal Kandel said that it was a challenging issue to conduct the 10th national games in Karnali Province in the absence of sufficient budget.

Two travel agents held for sending Nepalis to Russia

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 5

Police have arrested two travel agents on the charge of sending Nepalis to Russia to join the Russian Army.

The Kathmandu Valley Crime Investigation Office arrested 31-year-old Arjun Sunar of Gorkha Municipality-1, Gorkha, and 35-year-old Sher Bahadur Rai of Necha Salyan Rural Municipality-1, Solukhumbu.

The victim has complained that the travel operators sent them to Russia at the rate of Rs. 600,000 per person saying that the hotels in Russia would offer them attractive salaries.

A complaint has been lodged against Sher Bahadur Rai and Arjun Sunar, who are told as owner of Alaska Travel and Tours by Shankar Karki after his return to Nepal when he denied working in the Russian Army. The company has also been found sending Rajan Rai and Bikash Rai to Russia for their enrolment in the Russian Army by giving them false assurance by charging Rs. 600,000 per person.

Even though Karki was sent to Russia, after reaching there, Karki said, he refused to work in the Russian Army and told a person who came to pick him up at the airport that he came here to work in a hotel. Karki said that he had to pay 800 dollars to the person who came to pick him up at the airport.

After being told to work in the Russian Army, he returned to Nepal and filed a complaint against the persons who sent him to Russia.

According to Superintendent of Police (SP) and Spokesperson for the Valley Crime Investigation Office Rabindra Regmi, it was found that the travel agencies have been found making fake documents to send them to Russia.

They were arrested on charges of human trafficking and the Crime Investigation Office has sent them to the District Police Range, Kathmandu, for further legal action.

Rajan Rai and Bikash Rai, who went with Karki, have already joined the Russian Army.

Nepal has no dearth of working-age population

BY MANJIMA DHAKAL
Kathmandu, Jan. 5

In the 1990s, the fertility rate of Nepali women was 5.8 children. However, the most recent census data, 2021 has revealed a significant decline, with the current fertility rate falling to 2.1 children per woman, a level considered ideal for the present demographic landscape. While this shift aligns with global trends towards lower fertility rates, stakeholders are expressing concerns about the potential for further decline in the coming years if the current trends persist.

The Population Studies Department of Tribhuvan University emphasises the crucial role of fertility, mortality and migration as key components shaping population dynamics. Despite having the desired fertility rate, there is growing anxiety regarding the impact of high migration rates. Stakeholders are wary that huge migration could lead to population imbalances, affecting various aspects of societal and economic structures.



A total of 2,169,478 Nepalis are now living abroad, an increase from 1,921,494 in 2011. Among them, 1,684,029 are males and 237,400 are females.

Since 2011, more and more Nepalis have migrated abroad in search of better opportunities which in turn is a critical factor for the lower population growth rate in Nepal, read the census report of 2021.

Despite the coronavirus pandemic, more than 240,000 labour permits were granted in 2021 alone, which does not include workers moving to India. The census report also highlighted that the number of women who migrated to foreign countries has increased by 71 per cent compared to the previous surveys owing to the development of information and technology.

Dr. Padma Prasad Khatiwada, Associate Professor in the Population Studies Department of TU, highlighted the global trend of a significant migration of young populations from poor nations to wealthy ones. He emphasised the challenge faced by developed countries in managing their youthful demographic entry, while others grapple with potential shortages in the working-age population shortly.

The census indicates that 27 per cent of the current population falls below 15 years of age while the ageing society (above 65 years) constitutes 7 per cent and is on an upward course. Concurrently, the working-age population, spanning 15 to 64 years, stands at 66 per cent, which is a perfect composition. Despite having a sufficient working-age demographic, Dr. Khatiwada emphasised that the numbers suggest the potential for significant contribution to national prosperity now. But, it can't happen because of various challenges.

As the working-age population moving towards an ageing population due to a low birth rate, it is the right moment to use the existing workforce for national progress. But, unfortunately, this potential is hindered by the increasing trend of youth migrating abroad in pursuit of better opportunities, Khatiwada said.

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Power-purchase deal pleases private sector

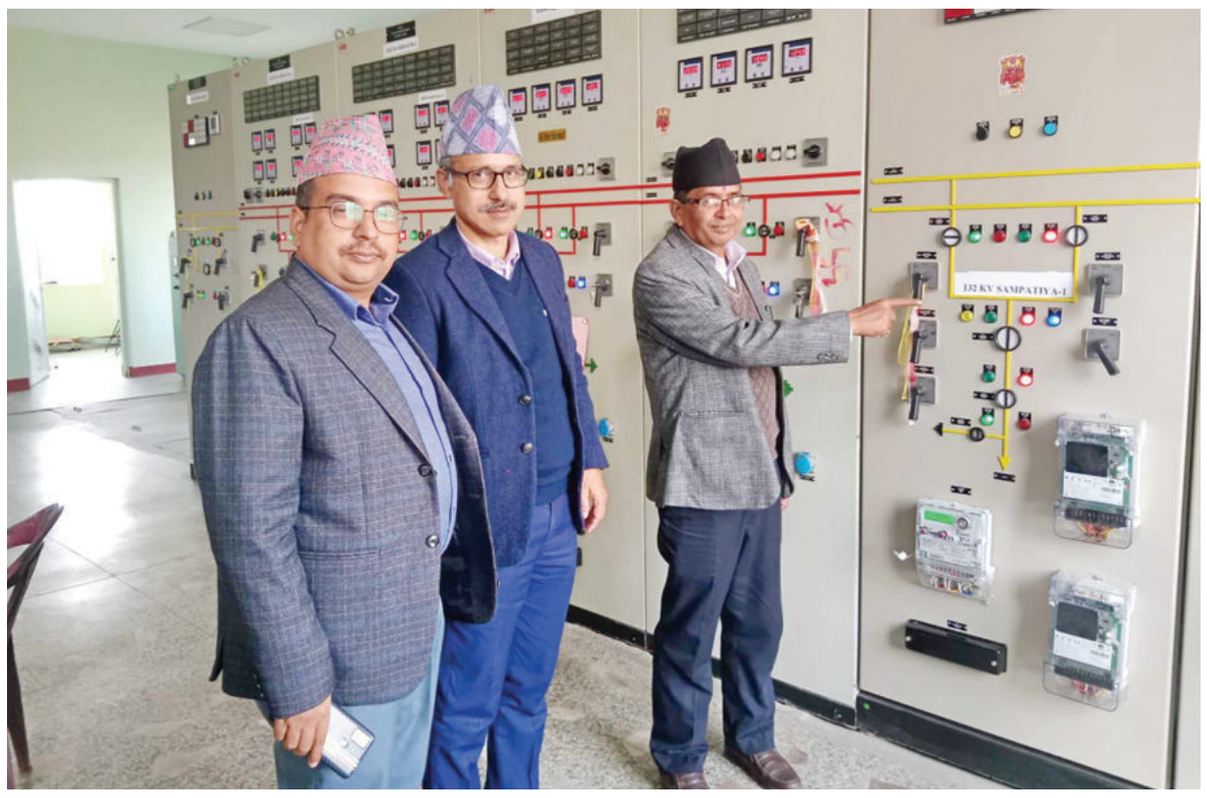


PHOTO: LAXMAN PAUDEL/TRN

Officials of Nepal Electricity Authority observing the transmission line with project officials on Friday.

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 5

The private sector has expressed its happiness over the long-term power agreement signed between Nepal and India on Thursday. They said that the agreement raised a ray of hope among them for the investment in the hydropower projects.

President of the Independent Power Producers' Association, Nepal Ganesh Karki said that the private sector was excited by the signing of the agreement for the long-term power trade and urged the governments of both countries for its proper implementation.

"The agreement signed for the export of at least 10,000 megawatts of electricity to India in 10 years is a very welcome step. It is historic work of the present government in the field of the hydropower sector as it has paved the way for the maximum utilisation of hydropower potential by increasing investment in this sector," he told The Rising Nepal.

Stating that with the inking of the agreement between Nepal and, Nepal's electricity will have easy access to India's huge market, he said that it would encourage domestic and foreign investors to invest in Nepal's hydropower projects. A long-term electricity trade agreement was signed between the governments of Nepal and India on Thursday.

According to the agreement, within the next 10 years, India will purchase 10,000 megawatts of electricity from Nepal. Also, the agreement has ensured an export route for electricity produced in Nepal. Karki stressed the need to create an investment environment by making amendments to the existing acts and policies to attract investment in hydropower.

"It is a must to increase investment in the hydropower sector to produce electricity to meet not only the national demand but also export it to India after the latter committed to importing at least 10,000 MW in 10 years. Bangladesh is also showing interest in purchasing power from Nepal. So, the government should address the hurdles in the process of constructing hydropower," he said.oThe government has set a target of generating 28,000 MW of hydropower by 2035. Out of that, 13,500 MW of electricity is expected to be consumed domestically and the remaining 15,000 MW of electricity will be exported to neighbouring countries, India and Bangladesh. Currently, Nepal's power generation capacity has reached 2,892 megawatts.

Meanwhile, president of Nepal Chamber of Commerce Rajendra Malla has said that the 1,200 MW capacity Budhigandaki Hydropower Project should be promoted immediately in a public-private partnership.

Addressing the Agriculture, Tourism and Business Promotion fair organised by the Gorkha Chamber of Commerce in Gorkha, President Malla emphasised that the construction process of Budhigandaki hydropower project should be started immediately in the public-private partnership.

He said, "There has been an agreement to export 10,000 megawatts of electricity from Nepal to India in 10 years. To implement it, it is necessary to advance the Budhigandaki Hydropower project in the public-private partnership. The private sector is ready to invest in it." He said that the existing trade deficit could be reduced by exporting electricity.

Meanwhile, our Bhairahawa correspondent said that with the commissioning of the Nepal-India cross-border 132 kV double circuit transmission line, electricity up to 200 megawatts can now be transmitted from it. The 132 kV double circuit transmission line from Mainahiya in Rupandehi to Sampatiya in India has been commissioned.

Minister for Foreign Affairs NP Saud and Minister for External Affairs of India Dr. S Jaishankar jointly inaugurated the Mainahiya-Sampatiya 132 kV transmission lines on Thursday. Hari Prasad Pandey, chief of the Mainahiya-Sampatiya 132 kV transmission line project, said that a successful test was also conducted by charging the transmission line.

With the successful test, now the way to export electricity to India through this transmission line has been paved, he said. Pandey said that the transmission line was built to export electricity produced in the country to India.

He said that 180 to 200 megawatts of electricity can be bought and sold from the transmission line. At present Uttar Pradesh has structures of only 33 kV transmission lines. The Mainahiya-Sampatiya transmission line is now ready, and the cross-border electricity trade between Nepal and India will become easier, Pandey said.

A total of 96 towers have been constructed in the 28.5 km long transmission line project. As Uttar Pradesh, India's largest state, has the first and shortest 132 kV line, Nepal will be able to export maximum power through this line.

The substation required for the transmission line has been constructed in Mainahia of Siyari Rural Municipality. From the substation built here, a transmission line has been constructed by connecting the substation of Sampatiya (New Nautanwa) located in Uttar Pradesh, India.

The sixth meeting of the Energy Secretary-level Joint Steering Committee held between Nepal and India in Pokhara in January 2019 agreed to construct the New Nautanwa-Mainahiya line between India's Uttar Pradesh and Nepal.

After this, in October 2019, the seventh meeting of the Energy Secretary-level Joint Steering Committee held in Bangalore, India, decided to connect the transmission line to the New-Nautanwa (Sampatiya, India) substation.

OPMCM undergoes restructuring

RSS
Kathmandu, Jan. 5

The Office of the Prime Minister and Council of Ministers has been restructured. The OPMCM underwent major restructuring as announced by Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' in his address to the nation on December 26. The restructuring is in line with the announcement to make structural change in the OPMCM.

As per the revised structure proposal recently approved by the Cabinet, a total of 68 positions including three secretaries and seven joint-secretaries within the OPMCM have been removed.

Similarly, some branches and divisions of OPMCM have been merged while a separate division related to information technology has been established. The separate IT-related division was formed to further support the information technology developed in the country.

PM Dahal's press advisor Govinda Acharya shared that the OPMCM and PM's Secretariat have been restructured by cutting various quotas as per PM Dahal's plan to make OPMCM efficient and functional.

Meanwhile, PM's advisor Acharya has said relieving Ganga Dahal, the PM's daughter, who is serving as private secretary to the Prime Minister of the post will be non-cooperation to the Prime Minister and make him unsuccessful. Ganga, the central member of the CPN (Maoist Center), has been working as the Prime Minister's private secretary since the beginning of his term.

> Some branches and divisions of OPMCM have been merged while a separate division related to information technology has been established.

The matter is not raised within the party and the government, and voices from outside to remove her from the Prime Minister's private secretariat keep no meaning, he said.

"Ganga has been a great support to the Prime Minister during his hard times, both as the government head and the party chair, be it during the tragic losses of his son and spouse or throughout his tenure as the Prime Minister. It will be non-cooperation with the Prime Minister to remove her from the post," he added.

Manish Thapa appointed Honorary Consul of Costa Rica

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 5

Dr. Manish Thapa has been appointed as the Honorary Consul of Costa Rica for Nepal. Nepal and Costa Rica had established diplomatic relations on August 16, 1977.

Dr. Thapa said that in his capacity as the Honorary Consul, he would endeavour to facilitate tourism, cultural exchange, trade and investment between Nepal and Costa Rica, striving to foster understanding and cooperation for the mutual benefit of both nations.

The Costa Rican Government has also extended its congratulations to Dr. Thapa and looks forward to a prosperous partnership with Nepal. Dr. Thapa facilitated a high-level official visit by then Prime Minister K P Sharma Oli to Costa Rica in October 2018 while serving as a professor at the United Nations-mandated University for Peace (UPEACE) in Costa Rica.

The office of the Honorary Consulate of Costa Rica in Nepal is located in Sanepa at the Global Equity Fund's office, which will provide essential consular services to both Costa Rican and Nepali citizens, serving as a vital bridge between the two nations.Dr. Thapa is a Founding Managing Partner of the Global Equity Fund, Nepal's first licensed Private Equity and Venture Capital Fund.

In addition, he holds positions as a Board of Directors at Laxmi Sunrise Bank, and is on the Board of Directors at the Asian Institute of Management Technology, Nepal Private Equity Association and American Chamber of Commerce in Nepal (AmCham Nepal).

He is also the Executive Chairman of the Nepal Infrastructures Investment Fund (NIIF). Dr. Thapa's academic contributions include the United Nations-mandated University for Peace (UPEACE), University of Warsaw, McGill University, the University of Tokyo, and Tribhuvan University.



PHOTO: NISHA RAI/TRN

Mayor of Kathmandu Metropolitan City Balendra Shah and Dharan Sub-metropolitan City mayor Harka Sangpang Rai during the inauguration of five day Dharan Festival organised on the occasion of 123 years of establishment of Dharan city in Dharan on Friday.

Minister Gurung urges to use locally produced goods

RSS
Kathmandu, Jan. 5

Urban Development Minister Sita Gurung has stressed the need of using domestic products and services for their promotion.

Talking to media persons after visiting the 'Ninth Nepal Wood International Exhibition' organised at Bhrikutimandap today, Minister Gurung shared that although the government has adopted a policy of promoting Nepal's products, it has not been effectively implemented.

"The government has made a policy to use locally-produced products as much as possible. But it has not been effectively implemented. There is no impossible if we want this", she mentioned. She further said it was necessary to make arrangement of discount as well as other facility from government in order to promote timber products produced in Nepal and make it competitive.

The Guidelines related to use of domestic products at public bodies-2071, has the provision that the goods used by public bodies should be locally produced. Though the guidelines were introduced, there was a problem in its implementation, she added.

The Urban Development Minister opined that there is a misconception among the general people that the reliability of goods produced in the country is less and foreign goods are of better quality. The expo organised by media Space Solutions Pvt. Ltd and India's Futurex Trade Fair and Events Pvt Ltd would run till Sunday.

The Ninth Nepal Wood International Expo, 2024 commenced in Bhrikutimandap here today.The three-day event is jointly organised by Media Space Solutions Pvt Ltd and India's Futurex Trade Fair and Events Pvt Ltd.

As the organisers claimed, it is Nepal's largest exhibition on wood and woodworking machinery, furniture production technologies, tools and fittings, interior design, accessories, raw materials and products. It aims to inform visitors about latest wood products and new wood technologies in furniture production industry.

Media Space Solutions managing director Sirjal Bhattarai said woodworking companies from Nepal, India, China, Taiwan, and Malaysia are taking part in the fair. The expo will conclude on Sunday.

RUKUM PASCHIM PRODUCES HONEY WORTH RS. 25 MILLION

RSS
Rukum Paschim, Jan. 5

The Rukum Paschim district has produced 21 metric tons of honey this year and the market value for the honey is some 25 million rupees. The volume of honey produced this year is higher than the previous years and the farmers created some 25 million by selling honey, Chief of District Agriculture Development Office Min Bahadur KC said.

Mostly, Baphikot, Athbiskot, Sanibheri, Musikot and Triveni produce high-quality honey in the district. The farmers are selling the honey at Rs 1,000 per kilogram in the market. The honey produced here is also exported to Kathmandu, Dang and Nepalgunj as well.

Office Chief KC shared that the district recorded good production of honey as the honeybee got sufficient pasturelands due to limited rainfall in the time of honey production. The Office has been supporting the beekeepers through bee block development programme and the need-based support is extended to the farmers for better output.

As high as 200 farmers in Rukum West have kept beehives for commercial purpose by keeping modern and wooden hives.

Due to lucrative income from honey production, the locals here have switched to this business in the recent years. '

However, gradual decrease in pastureland for bees, maximum use of pesticides and limited technical knowledge on beekeeping remain some of the big challenges in this sector.

Manang farmers get yak breeder from Solukhumbu



PHOTO:YADU PRASAD BHATTA/TRN

Farmers waiting their turn at Yak Genetic Resource Centre Friday.

BY YADU PRASAD BHATTA
Manang, Jan. 5

Nine yaks, brought from Solukhumbu to improve the yak breed in Gandaki Province, reached Manang on Wednesday evening. The purebred yaks, raised at the Yak Genetic Resource Centre in Syangboche, were distributed to the farmers in Manang amid a programme on Thursday.

Suresh Thakali, the Chairman of the Manang Yak Chauri Breeding and Conservation Organisation, said that the yaks were distributed in three rural municipalities of Manang in the presence of lawmaker Munindra Jung Gurung. He mentioned that a yak was distributed to the Pisang group in Ngisyang Rural Municipality, and another yak was provided to three sheds in Bhraka.

Three yaks, one for each of the three groups in Nason Rural Municipality, have been distributed. Likewise, in Chame Rural Municipality one yak is allocated for a group of three sheds. The remaining two yaks are kept at the Manang Yakchaunri Breeding and Conservation Organisation," said Thakali.

Two Yaks were allocated to each rural municipality, but due to the lack of coordination, the Yaks are not yet distributed in Narphu Rural Municipality, informed Thakali. He also said that the farmers have to contribute 25 per cent of the investment. He added that all the yaks are insured and cannot be slaughtered or sold by the farmers.

Narendra Rai, the Chief of the Animal Services and Veterinary Office in Manang, said that the yaks were distributed to the farmers across the district under the leadership of the Manang Yakchaunri Organisation.

The yaks, all males brought by the Directorate of Livestock and Fisheries Development of Gandaki Province, were delivered by a team, including Bal Kumar Shrestha. The directorate informed that the government priced these yaks at 20,000 to 25,000 each.

Health Minister pledges to solve problems of BPKIHS

BY NISHA RAI
Dharan, Jan. 5

Despite conflicts, corruption and other setbacks, the Dharan-based B.P. Koirala Institute of Health Sciences (BPKIHS), aka Ghopa Camp, has continuously been a lifesaver for the people of Eastern Nepal.

It has not been long since Dharan´s locals´ took to the streets demanding an end to self-centered politics and corruption in the BPKHIS.

After the changes made following the series of protests, the health academy has improved in some basic areas of medical service delivery. However, much more needs to be done.

The locals have once again raised their hope to see Ghopa Camp, a government institution, providing quality services effectively and efficiently at an affordable cost for all when Minister for Health and Population Mohan Bahadur Basnet visited the BPKIHS and assured to further improve its condition.

Minister Basnet pledged to solve the problems of BPKIHS during his visit to the health academy on Friday

He inspected the institution´s emergency and OPD wards, surgery building and other areas Addressing a gathering at the BPKIHS, Minister Basnet assured the officials, doctors, students and patients to improve the institution as it is a pride of the nation.

"Legal provisions led to a deduction of 50 seats in medical education for BPKIHS this academic session, it will not be deducted in the next. The Medical Education Act needs several amendments," said Minister Basnet. "BPKIHS officials have also demanded an MRI machine which costs around Rs. 300 million. Despite the cost, it will be procured for BPKIHS this year. The ministry is also positive to address the demand regarding dialysis machines," he added.

Minister Basnet informed that a citizen insured under the government health insurance scheme would soon be allowed to receive treatment at any hospital registered under the scheme by amending some provisions of the scheme.

"If a citizen cannot afford treatment, s/he can visit any government health centre with a recommendation from the local government. Those patients will be treated for free. No citizen shall die in lack of treatment due to economic reasons," Minister Basnet said.

He also stated to start the halted promotion process under prevailing provisions in a transparent manner.

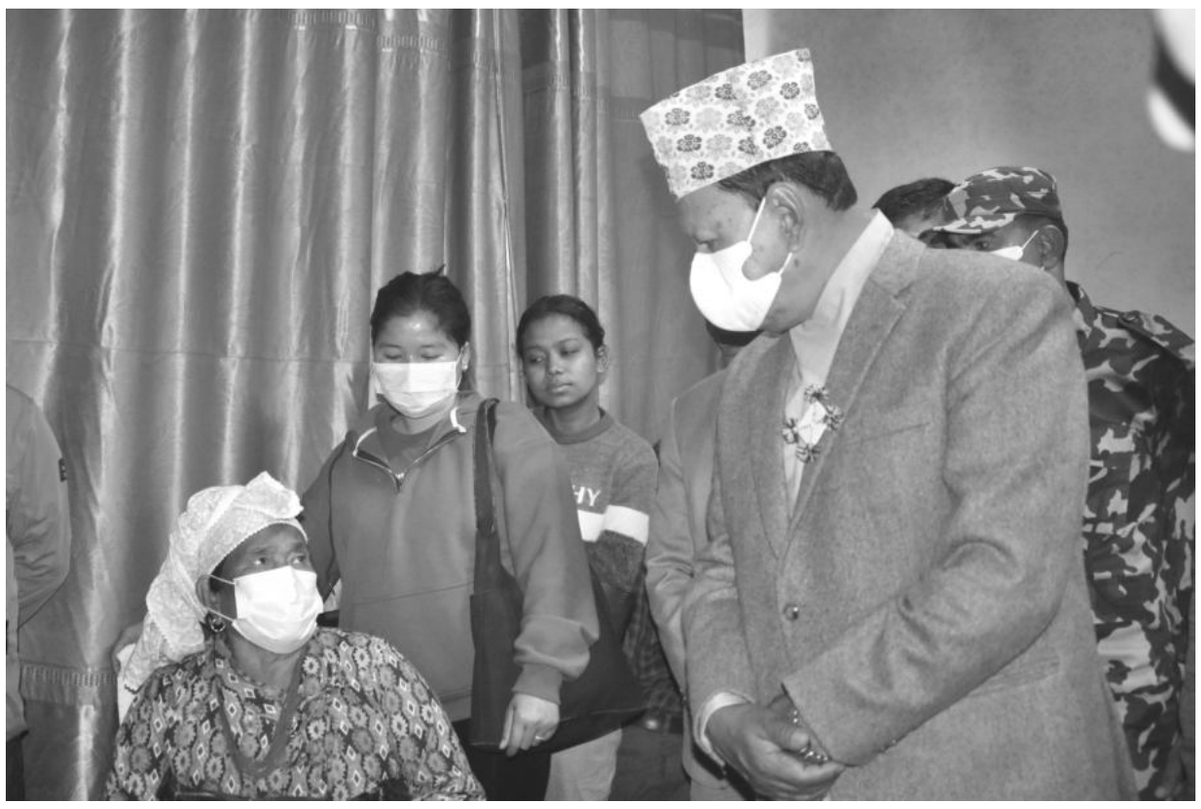


PHOTO: NISHA RAI/TRN

Minister for Health and Population Mohan Bahadur Basnet inspecting the emergency and OPD wards, surgery building and other areas of BPKIHS in Dharan, Friday.

Govt initiates process to appoint VC of TU via open competition

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 5

The government has initiated a process to appoint the Vice-Chancellor of the Tribhuvan University (TU) through an open competition.

Publishing a notice in the Gorkhapatra on Friday, the Committee formed to Select and Recommend the Vice Chancellor of Tribhuvan University has sought applications from qualified candidates for the post of Vice Chancellor of the country's oldest university. This is the first time the government is going to appoint VC in TU through an open competition.

In his televised address to the nation on the occasion of the completion of one year in office on December 26, Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' announced that political appointments in universities would come to an end and a merit-based approach would be adopted to appoint Vice Chancellors in universities.

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' on Friday instructed the Committee to correct the notice removing the provision of three years of experience of working as office bearer of the university.

The notice has come in line with the Prime Minister's announcement.

Political interferences are blamed for the deteriorating condition of TU and other universities in Nepal.

Anyone meeting the qualifications mentioned in the notice can submit their application with a 3, 000-word Vision Paper and a 5,000-word Professional Work Plan to the Ministry of Education, Science and Technology, Singha Durbar with 10 days, read the notice.

> The notice has come in line with the Prime Minister's announcement. Political interferences are blamed for the deteriorating condition of TU and other universities in Nepal.

Meanwhile, Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' on Friday instructed the Committee to correct the notice removing the provision of three years of experience of working as office bearer of the university.

The secretariate of the Prime Minister in a statement said that the PM instructed the Committee through the Ministry of Education, Science and Technology to remove the provision of experience citing that the provision would make only the former office bearers eligible to apply, and it would impose a syndicate in meritocracy which was not the intention of the government.

He instructed the ministry to ensure that any academician living at home and abroad could apply for the post of the VC, otherwise improving the university would be impossible.

Man who smuggled 26 kg gold via TIA admits how he did his job

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 5

Chandra Ghale from Gorkha, who was arrested in the 14-kg gold smuggling case, has so far smuggled 26 kg of gold from the Tribhuvan International Airport (TIA) during his three flights from Dubai.

A case has been filed in the Kathmandu District Court against Ghale.

According to the statement furnished by Ghale in front of the probe committee led by revenue officer Mani Ram Paudel of the TIA, Ghale used to get Rs. 70,000 from the agent each time he smuggled the gold.

The probe committee said that he smuggled gold three times including the 14 kg of the gold which was confiscated from the TIA on December 8, 2023.

According to the statement of Chandra Ghale, Min Bahadur Ghale, also from Gorkha, was involved in the smuggling.

During the interrogation, Ghale also said that a man named Min Bahadur Ghale used to send him to Dubai to receive the gold giving him 5 dirhams, the official currency of the United Arab Emirates, and the number printed on the currency.

He stated that he did not know the person who gave him the gold in Dubai, but a gang used to give him a jacket containing the gold based on the note or currency and number given by Min Bahadur Ghale in Nepal. Chandra also said that his visa and air tickets were managed by Min Bahadur.

Chandra also mentioned in the statement that he brought gold from Dubai and kept it in the red dustbin in the arrival room's toilet made for the differently-able persons at the TIA. He stated that the cleaning staff, AC maintenance staff and plumbers used to bring out the gold from the dustbin and give it to the members of the smuggling group.

Chandra also mentioned in his statement that he only brought the gold from Dubai. Ghale said that Ankit Agrawal and a person named 'Guru' used to give him the gold in Dubai after completing all the legal procedures and paying the customs.

"The 14 kg gold recovered on December 8 in Kathmandu was provided to me by an unknown person of Indian origin in Dubai after calling me at Gate No. 2 of Gol Quest Market after verifying the 5 Dirham currency note and number in it," Chandra was quoted in his statement.

Inter-district security coordination meet decides to tighten security

BY CHITRA MIJAR
Sindhupalchok, Jan. 5

An inter-district security coordination meeting held in Charikot of Dolakha has decided to further tighten the security measures in three districts to control smuggling, crimes and road accidents.

The meeting that concluded on Thursday decided to take further measures to bolster the security of the districts to maintain peace and order and control crimes.

The meeting was led by the Chief District Officers of the three districts-Sindhupalchok, Dolakha and Ramechhap-- who also act as the head of the District Security Committee.

CDO Jhakka Prasad Acharya of Sindhupalchowk said that the meeting took decisions to control possible criminal activities like drug dealing and abuse that may happen near the border points of the three districts.

> The meeting further decided to take measures to reduce road accidents, control thefts and smuggling escaping the customs routes, control tax evasion and exchange information among the three districts.

"We also decide to maintain peace and security by increasing the surveillance at the border points," he said.

The meeting further decided to take measures to reduce road accidents, control thefts and smuggling escaping the customs routes, control tax evasion and exchange information among the three districts.

CDO Acharya said that the officials also decided to increase coordination among the security agencies of the districts.

Officials of the three districts have been holding such meetings every month in rotation.

After the meeting, the government and security officials said that the things decided in the security meeting would be implemented.

But smuggling, illegal activities and revenue leakages have not been stopped from the border areas of all three districts, they said.

OWLS DISAPPEARING FROM FORESTS OF UDAYAPUR

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Gaighat, Jan. 5

The endangered Eurasian Eagle Owl, commonly known as Huchil or Latokosero was once abundant in the eastern belt of Udayapur district. But now, these endangered species are on the verge of extinction because of the lack of food and habitat.

Locals said that owls, usually abundant in winter and the rainy season, are no longer spotted in Mainamaini, Babala, Champakot and Boptang of Chaudandigadhi in Chaudandi Municipality, and Siddhipur areas in Belaka Municipality of the district. Hunting and habitat destruction are blamed for the extinction of these endangered species.

Bal Bahadur Rai of Mainamaini in Belka Municipality-8 said that the owls were plentiful in the forests and cliffs until a few years ago, but now catching their sight is rare.

Man Bahadur Magar of Siddhipur in Chaudandigadhi said that the habitat of owls was being encroached upon by people. Additionally, there is illegal hunting, and the bird is facing extinction due to a lack of food.

Overuse of chemical fertilisers and pesticides, increased deforestation, overgrazing, electrocution and forest fires too are affecting these fowls, he said.

He added, "During both winter and rainy seasons until four or five years ago, the villagers used to hear the sounds of birds all night in the nearby trees."

Longest suspension bridge near complete

BY VIJAY KUMAR SAH
Dhalkebar, Jan. 5

Construction on Nepal's longest suspension bridge is nearly complete.

The bridge, being built over the Kamala River and connecting Dhanusha's Kathal with Siraha's Malahaniya, is set to be 1,501 metres long and four feet wide.

The bridge is being built for Rs. 280 million provided by the federal government. Thani Construction Service of Kathmandu is the contractor constructing the bridge and has promised to complete it by January end.

Binod Kumar Mandal, an engineer representing the contractor, said that even though the contract allows them to work till July 15, 2024, they are working to finish work six months before that. Thani Construction began work on September 17, 2022.

"We have finished everything on the Dhanusha side and are about to finish constructing stairs on the Siraha side," Mandal said. "We will open the bridge to the public in a few days."

One local Mukesh Sharma assumed that the bridge would be used by nearly 5,000 people daily. Currently, the people of Siraha and Janakpur need to use the East-West Highway or Indian routes to travel between each other's districts.

The suspension bridge is also expected to act as an alternative to the motorable bridge that was built over the Kamala River under the Postal Highway project. The bridge was expected to prove a boon to the residents of Dhanusha and Siraha but it collapsed even before it could be inaugurated.

Another local Binde Mukhiya hoped that the bridge would allow farmers to find markets for their produce and boost tourism.



PHOTO: VIJAY KUMAR SAH/TRN

The construction work of Nepal's longest suspension bridge is going over the Kamala River which will connect Dhanusha's Kathal with Siraha's Malahaniya.

NEWS BRIEF

Relief aid to family of deceased

Surkhet: Karnali Province government has decided to provide Rs. 200,000 to the family of Sujan Rawat of Mahabu Rural Municiplaity-6 who was killed in the Bal Kumari incident on Friday last week.

Chief Minister of Karnali Province Raj Kumar Sharma said that the amount was given as relief to the family of Sujan who lost his life during the demonstration in Balakumari, Lalitpur. "The relief of Rs. 200,000 will be given to the family of Sujan Rawat, who died in the Balkunari incident. The Council of Ministers will decide to this effect," said Chief Minister Sharma. Rawat was cremated in Dailekh on Tuesday.

Two held with Rs. 1.4 million

Bardibas: A patrolling squad of the Armed Police Force (APF) arrested two persons along with one Indian citizen from Matihani near the Nepal-India border point.

The patrolling squad arrested 23-year-old Raju Yadav of Janakpur Sub-metropolitan City-19 and Indian citizen Abadesh Mandal, 48, of Sitamadhi, India.

Deputy Superintendent of Police of the APF of No. 9 Headquarters, Bikash Adhikari said that the security team confiscated Rs. 1.4 million. They were arrested by the team of the APF deployed under the command of APF inspector Bhola Kumar Shrestha on Thursday night.

TRN

THOUGHT FOR TODAY

Coincidence is God's way of remaining anonymous.
-- Albert Einstein

Building Trust In Public Institutions



Dev Raj Dahal

The defining feature of public institutions is impersonal trust-mediating rational agencies assigned to perform specialised tasks in society. Human life flourishes in interactions with each other and builds trust in public life. Trust increases the efficiency of institutions. The attachment of Nepalis to a variety of interactive economic, civic and political institutions is vital for coordinating their actions and minimising transaction costs. Building trust in leadership and key institutions for their ability to respond to societal challenges overcomes the crisis of legitimacy and enhances their utility and rationality. Public institutions of Nepal are obliged to perform constitutional duties impartially, tackle common challenges, protect the most vulnerable and hold wisdom to shape a common future. This means non-partisan formation of institutional leadership is essential.

Mark. E. Warren argues "trusting an institution amounts to knowing that its constitutive rules, values and norms are shared by participants and that they regard them as binding." Ironically, the peril of fading public trust on public institutions of Nepal such as politics, public security, health, education, economy, etc. marks their pale luster. The nation's business enterprises and foreign institutions hire private companies for their security. They find the investment climate is vitiated by a shaky political milieu. Nepali authorities travel abroad for health checkups, youths migrate abroad for quality education and job opportunities and workers and businesspersons rely more on the global labour and capital markets for their progress. Restoring this waning trust of Nepalis in their own institutions bit by bit is vital to spur their sociability of flare and rhythm.

Civic patriotism

The civic world in old times was embedded in locally active upswing of ethnic, caste, religious and occupational solidarity. The radius of trust gyrated in the in-group sphere which did not emit at citizenship level. With the spread of scientific progress, democracy, citizenship rights and growing complexity of society, the stretch of political bonds shifted more towards self-chosen associational trust. Now politics is not only defined by conflict of interests, identities and ideologies but also by an area of cooperation, peaceful competition and trust. Teamwork and coalition culture have emerged in Nepal as an imperative caused by fragmentation of political spheres, introduction of proportional election and inability of any political party to gain requisite majority in the parliament. As a result, political leaders from one party marshal resources and support from the other to form the government. The edifice of civic patriotism of people is extending into membership in a myriad of functional formal and informal institutions. Social movements are transcending conventional political boundaries defined by class-based binary code of ideology, organisation and worldview. Maoist-Center, even if it is ranked third force, has formed a coalition government on the basis of bridging trust lent by others though some of its supporters have despicable casts.

The mainstream Nepali parties have catch-all brands. A number of them are class-based. A few others are movement and issue oriented. The non-class based forces are fighting for ecological, peace, gender and workers' rights and justice. A steep rise of civic federations of indigenous people, cultural groups, local authorities, human rights bodies, NGOs, charity-based institutions etc. serve as change agents of society. Powerful networks of civic institutions combine a sense of social capital with inclusion, representation, political effectiveness and improved faith in their bridging potential. Some political parties, however, face trust slumps for their declining passion to control the cycle of exclusion, corruption, cronyism and impunity. Their tepid response to the concern of the general public is the main reason. New awareness brought about by information has sponsored distrust of many institutions including part of the media circle for their failure to suit the public. Electoral swing of de-alignment in party politics too hints at a deep crisis of trust. Some parties embodying fellow-feeling in leadership and civic enterprise seek to erode the preexisting inequalities of gender, caste and class relations to raise trust in civic virtues. Others built on vertical style face harsh challenges from their electorates. They question the exercise of discretionary power of their leaders in candidate selection for fear of the party's festering clout and turning aspiring leaders distrustful and restless.

The rights-based Nepali constitution holds little meaning if top-down process of politics flags the choice and voice of the people. It only prompts Nepalis to demand from the state institutions to fulfill all rights beyond their capacity and thus eroding trust in them. The institutional erosion in the nation is marked by the distribution of vital posts in all constitutional organs and public institutions among the mainstream parties and their skewed performance in supplying public goods and services. The public criticize them for not following their broader mandates and roles, becoming insensate to democratic pluralism, values of inclusion and civic culture of impersonality. To stop this erosion, institutional and policy reforms are vital so that Nepalis perceive that the public institutions work for them. The world of business in Nepal is family run and specific to certain castes. Despite big corporate leverage, it is seen covetous in hoarding profits during crisis time. Corporate ethics, no tax evasion and out-group reliance can improve trust and ties with the polity and the people.

A society nurturing inter-institutional trust is deemed most effective because it coordinates the actions of all actors in the resolution of problems and gets success in attaining common good. Nepal's educational institutions, for example, are created to foster centers of learning about theoretical and applied research and teaching, doing jobs and engaging in entrepreneurship. Their specialised roles are expected to supply working qualifications and good knowledge, with curriculum and contents constantly tailored to the needs of Nepali ecology, economy, society and polity. They are supposed to be the places for higher learning throughout life, opening their doors to varied opportunities who desire either to continue their studies, cultivate their knowledge to satisfy their yearning for learning and research in many areas of national life. This has enabled them to become leading partners in international cooperation, facilitate exchanges of researchers, teachers and students, ensure that quality education is made widely available for all and they develop a culture of trust and civility so that the public do not go against each other.

> The nation urgently requires a public policy debate for renewing its civic life, so that new socialisation patterns can build public trust in the institutions of governance.

Institutions of public administration work best when they have competent leadership with vision, will, integrity, autonomy, courage and resources to make a difference in the life of Nepalis. The absence of these attributes makes them vulnerable to bureaucratic charade which follows the orders from above without thinking and reflecting. If authorities are raised and reared on a patronage basis they cannot perform institutional tasks in a meritocratic way. Certain elements of folk Nepali societies are still fatalistic, less exposed to civic virtues. They are caught in primordial attachments nurturing cave-men feeling of dread of outside and fear of change. The interactive model of some locally rooted cross-class voluntary associations has helped to generate scientific consciousness to rub off the existing fatalistic attitude. Local community, the government and the international community each have a responsibility to initiate educational reform and training of people in quality education and action so that they are de-rationalised. Only then Nepalis can develop a habit of obedience to constitutional values and norms, put trust on the strength of institutions and put value on them. The nation urgently requires a public policy debate for renewing its civic life, so that new socialisation patterns can build public trust in the institutions of governance and foster social exchanges, cross-fertilisation of ideas and sharing of cultures so that diverse Nepalis would get along.

Socialisation infuses the art of learning about democracy, the value of public and private institutions and self-discovery. In diverse societies like Nepal absence of trust stokes a politics of difference across the faultlines of the nation so far glued by its syncretic culture, a culture that helped people to enlarge the sphere of identity from an individual person to a public citizen and enabled them to understand the power dynamics of families, peer groups, schools, political parties and the state to the global governance. Such a view holds that individuals born in a family are not isolated atoms. They are connected to the change of time and context and learn to build trust in their ties with several networks, institutions, associations, federations, NGOs and civil societies for their benefit. Socialisation conceives a condition in which communication and participation are free of domination. This fuses individual identities in democratic public life. Public institutions are intended to serve the public and national interests. The more they satisfy these interests, the better they acquire trustworthiness and creditworthiness and greater the stability of democratic regime. Independent media play a big role in creating trust in leaders, parties, polity, civil society and business institutions but political correctness of some of them has gone wild, others receive kickbacks for projecting their desired images which undermines their profession and consequently their narration faces public trust deficits.

Institutional culture

Institutional context defines self-identities of Nepalis and is sustained by its cultural values which supply them with ways of feeling, speaking, knowing and acting. People often look for examples from their superiors and public figures. If authorities in different spheres of life govern in the spirit of the Constitution, they become not only a "role model" but can also lift the nation to a new era of order, justice and peace. The animating vision of promoting institutional culture and memory is expected to give each Nepali the means to take full advantage of civic aptitude, competence, brilliance and accomplishment to participate in the Nepali society, economy and politics. The idea of lifelong institutional learning reconciles other components: legitimate struggle, which provides motives and incentives to excel others; collaboration, which adds synergy for sharing culture and re-sparking the economy; and institutional trust, which unites people to engage in collective action. Trust can be shored up if Nepali authorities rise above themselves, evolve civic culture and give primacy to public interests, not just the partisan interests. Confidence in public institutions too can be strengthened if they operate under constitutional rules of the game.

(Former Reader at the Department of Political Science, TU, Dahal writes on political and social issues.)

Winter Layering

AASHISH MISHRA

Winter is upon us, bringing with it frigid mornings and chilly days. If possible, this is the season to stay in bed all day, wrapped in blankets and/or in front of a heater. But, since that is not feasible for most of us, we have to do the next best thing – layer up when leaving our rooms. Clothes on clothes on clothes to prevent the icy clutches of the season from getting us. It may not be the most glamorous way to go out into the world, but it is what is needed to keep out the cold.

> A significant portion of body heat escapes through the head, making hats or caps non-negotiable elements of winter clothing.

The first layer to put on would, obviously, be the thermal garments, what we in Nepal normally call thermocoats. Let us opt for high-quality thermal tops and bottoms to form a snug base layer that traps body heat and keeps us warm. If we sweat a lot, we should choose bodywarmers that also absorb moisture and keep us dry. Thermal garments, or bodywarmers, are the foundation on which successful winter layers stand and are the knights of our wardrobe that defend us from winter's frosty terror.

Once we have armoured ourselves with thermal garments, we can move on to the "base layer." This would comprise fleece, the soft and lightweight fabric that feels like a warm hug from an old lover. A fleece pullover is excellent to wear over bodywarmers or shirts. If we are also looking for style, we can go for vibrant colours or unique patterns, but the primary purpose of these clothes has to be warmth. An additional benefit of fleece is that it is breathable and does not constrict body movements.

But, as we enter January, a simple fleece outer may not be enough. We may need to bring out the big guns and call on the puffer jacket. This wonderfully puffy piece of clothing is not the boldest of fashion statements, but it is a powerhouse of warmth (prioritise feeling good over looking good). For maximum heat, we can go for a jacket with synthetic insulation that traps and retains heat. Puffer jackets are an indispensable part of winter layering, and we should make a purchase immediately if we do not have one in our wardrobe.

With the torso insulated, let us now move on to the neck, which is a particularly vulnerable outpost on the winter battlefield. We must never hesitate to wrap our necks, chins, ears and what have you in a cosy, oversized woollen scarf or muffler. When done right, this can also look elegant and add a touch of flair to our outfit. We can experiment with different kinds of scarves to find the most comfortable (read least itchy) one and get out into the world.

And what goes well with a muffler? A hat. A significant portion of body heat escapes through the head, making hats or caps non-negotiable elements of winter clothing. For maximum insulation, our caps must cover our entire scalp and our ears. Like scarves, hats can add to our personality and complement our overall look, but the priority should be head protection. Let's not mind looking like a monkey if we can stay as warm as a polar bear.

We cannot afford to neglect our extremities too. Gloves and socks need to be as carefully selected as jackets and pants. If we ride bikes, we need thick gloves made of leather or reinforced textiles that have reinforced stitching on the fingers and silicone grips for easy twisting of the throttle. If we use our phones a lot, we should invest in a pair of high-quality conductive gloves which will allow us to use touchscreens without exposing our fingers. Socks are relatively simpler and any woollen variety that keeps our feet warm and dry may do.

To complete our winter armour, we must consider an outer layer that shields us from the elements and ties our outfit together. A waterproof jacket is best because it will protect us in the event of unexpected winter rain. We can invest in additional features like adjustable hoods and cuffs or a customisable fit to enhance function. After thermocoats and puffer jackets though, additional outerwear may not be necessary.

In conclusion, in the grand tapestry of winter layering, each garment plays a crucial role in creating a warm cocoon for us to inhabit. By mastering the art of layering, we will be able to defeat winter's chill and fulfil the responsibilities the world demands of us. We can try to look good while doing it, but warmth should be the top goal because cold can cause some serious health problems too. Let us emphasise health over beauty.

The Pillars Of Green Wisdom



Emmanuel Macron

The ongoing war in Ukraine and the fighting in Gaza following Hamas's October 7 terrorist attack must not distract the world from our collective priorities: reducing our CO_2 emissions, aiming for carbon neutrality by 2050, preserving biodiversity, and fighting poverty and inequality. This is the doctrine France is implementing at an international level, through the Paris Pact for People and the Planet and the One Planet summits. It is now crystal clear that no country will work to protect the planet if the price it must pay leads its citizens into a socioeconomic dead-end.

The world's most advanced economies, which have also been the main CO_2 emitters since the industrial revolution, must move away from fossil fuels. If we want to meet the goals of the Paris climate agreement, this is nonnegotiable. Science has set the trajectory: we must move away from coal by 2030, from oil by 2045, and from gas by 2050. While the G7 countries bear the greatest responsibility, China, which is now the second-largest emitter in history, must be fully committed, too.

The threat posed by coal must be addressed first. Today, the 2,000 gigawatts (GW) of installed capacity emit enough CO_2 to take us above 1.5°C. While the International Energy Agency recommends withdrawing 92 GW per year, 500 GW of additional capacity is already planned. While it is the G7's responsibility to move away from coal by 2030, emerging economies are now the biggest coal consumers. In these countries, we need to speed up the financing of renewables, as well as nuclear power, which, as a manageable and a decarbonised energy source, must play a key role. We must also put private financing and trade at the service of the Paris agreement.

Vulnerable countries

The cost of investment must be higher for players in the fossil-fuel sector. We need a green interest rate and a brown interest rate. Similarly, we need a climate clause in our trade agreements, because we cannot simultaneously demand that our industries become greener while supporting the liberalisation of international trade in polluting products. For the most vulnerable countries, we must create conditions that enable them to finance their climate-change mitigation and adaptation efforts and access the green technologies that are the new engines of growth.

The results are already there: in two years, following the initiative we took in Paris in the spring of 2021, we have released over $100 billion in special drawing rights for vulnerable countries. By activating this "dormant asset," we are extending 20-year loans at near-zero interest rates to finance climate action and pandemic preparedness in the poorest countries. We have begun to change debt rules to suspend payments for such countries, should a climate shock occur. And we have changed the mandate of multilateral development banks, such as the World Bank, so that they take more risks and mobilise more private money.

We are going to continue working on this, including within the framework of the new loss and damage fund, where we must mobilise new private insurance mechanisms in the face of climate risk. We will start from the specific needs of the hardest-hit countries. In the first half of 2024, France and Bangladesh will sign an agreement to finance climate-change adaptation and loss and damage, with the French development agency contributing €1 billion ($1.1 billion) in investment, and the IMF extending up to $1 billion worth of SDRs in new loans. This also implies identifying, on a global scale, governance mechanisms for the most crucial challenges we will have to face in the coming years, access to water being one of the most pressing. In this regard, France and Kazakhstan will convene a One Water Summit during the United Nations General Assembly in September 2024.

> We cannot simultaneously demand that our industries become greener while supporting the liberalisation of international trade in polluting products.

Moreover, we must focus on building the basis of a "bio-economy" that will pay for the services provided by nature. Nature is our best technology to sequester carbon on a large scale. The countries with the most important carbon and biodiversity reserves, especially in the three main tropical forest basins, must obtain much greater resources, determined on a country-by-country basis, in exchange for their stewardship of these vital reserves. France has already launched three contracts of this type at COP28, with Papua New Guinea, the Republic of the Congo, and the Democratic Republic of the Congo.

Green transition

But reform of the voluntary carbon market is essential. We need to create an international carbon and biodiversity exchange that will allow governmental and private actors to organise voluntary carbon credit swaps, based on sufficiently ambitious criteria to avoid greenwashing, and to remunerate local communities. The ocean is our most important carbon sink, and we must protect it. France and Costa Rica will convene the third United Nations Ocean Conference in Nice in June 2025, with the aim of updating international law, including on the prohibition of plastic pollution and on protection of the deep sea and seabed. These reforms would also enable the development of national strategies for seaboard protection by countries with exclusive economic zones.

Finally, we will not succeed if we cannot reform the World Bank and the IMF, which play a prominent role in establishing the norms and financing the green transition on a global scale. Eighty years after their creation, these institutions remain underfunded, relative to the size of the global economy and population, and emerging and developing countries continue to be shut out of their governance. But we will not be able to agree on goals and financing until every country negotiating is on an equal footing.

(The author is President of France.)
-- Project Syndicate

50 YEARS AGO

THE RISING NEPAL

January 6, 1974

Nepalgunj Customs Office Revenue

Nepalgunj, Jan. 5: The Nepalgunj customs office collected a total of Rs. 27,45251/86 as revenue from goods imported into and exported from Nepal in the first half of the current fiscal year, reports RSS.

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Or send them to
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READER'S MAIL

Open Up New Tourist Sites



I am writing this to express my concern regarding the significant decline in tourism in Lumbini and Kanchanjungha, as highlighted in news report titled '*Tourist arrival down in Lumbini*' published on Jan 3 in this daily. Despite national recovery from the pandemic, the number of tourists visiting Lumbini remain below pre-pandemic levels, causing concern. The reluctance of domestic tourists to return and a significant decline in arrivals from foreign countries are alarming trends. Also, the drop in Kanchanjunga tourism is linked to harsh cold and closed accommodations. This worsens the problem.

Collaboration among stakeholders, government bodies, and tourism entrepreneurs is crucial. Initiatives are needed to tackle challenges and revive tourism in these historically important areas.

Sustainable strategies are needed to attract both domestic and international visitors, ensuring the economic well-being of these regions. What's more, the country should open up more tourist sites, which it has plenty, to lure tourists from far and wide.

Sharada Sharma
Bhairahawa

TAILPIECE

A man placed some flowers on the grave of his dearly departed mother and started back towards his car when his attention was diverted to another man kneeling at a grave. The man seemed to be praying with profound intensity and kept repeating, "Why did you have to die? Why did you have to die?"

The first man approached him and said, "Sir, I don't wish to interfere with your private grief, but this demonstration of pain is more than I've ever seen before. For whom do you mourn so deeply? A child? A parent?" The mourner took a moment to collect himself, then replied, "My wife's first husband."

NKorea fires over 200 artillery shells

AFP
North Korea, Jan. 5

North Korea fired more than 200 artillery shells near two South Korean islands on Friday, prompting evacuation orders for their residents, Seoul's defence ministry and local officials said.

The live firing follows repeated warnings from Kim Jong Un's regime in Pyongyang that it is prepared for war against South Korea and its US ally.

"The North Korean military conducted over 200 rounds of firing today from around 09:00 to 11:00 (1200 to 0200 GMT) in the areas of Jangsan-got in the northern part of Baengnyeong Island and the northern areas... of Yeonpyeong Island," a defense ministry official said at a briefing.

Yeonpyeong local officials told AFP that civilians had been told to evacuate, describing the order as a "preventative measure".

South Korea's Yeonpyeong Island is situated in the Yellow Sea. It is located approximately 80 kilometres west of Incheon and 12 kilometres south of the coastline of Hwanghae Province, North Korea.

Authorities on Baengnyeong Island also reported an evacuation order there.

We are making the evacuation announcements at the moment," a local district official at the Baengnyeong Island told AFP, adding that he had been told the South Korean military would conduct a naval drill shortly.

Pyongyang fired a barrage of 170 artillery shells onto Yeonpyeong island in November 2010, killing four people including two civilians in the first North Korean attack on a civilian area since the 1950-53 Korean War.

Relations between the two Koreas are at one of their lowest points in decades, after Kim enshrined the country's status as a nuclear power into the constitution while test-firing several advanced ICBMs.

At Pyongyang's key year-end policy meetings, Kim warned of a nuclear attack on the South and called for a build-up of the country's military arsenal ahead of armed conflict that he warned could "break out any time".

Kim accused the United States of posing "various forms of military threat" and ordered his armed forces to maintain the "overwhelming war response capability", according to KCNA's account of the meeting that ended on Saturday.

The meeting concluded that it is a "fait accompli that a war may break out on the Korean peninsula any time due to the enemies' reckless moves for invading the DPRK", KCNA said, using the acronym of the North's official name.

In an effort to deter Pyongyang, Washington deployed a nuclear-powered submarine in the South Korean port city of Busan this month and flew its long-range bombers in drills with Seoul and Tokyo.

The North has described the deployment of Washington's strategic weapons, such as B-52 bombers, in joint drills on the Korean peninsula as "intentional nuclear war provocative moves".

The military "should rapidly respond to any possible nuclear crisis and put continuous spurs to the preparations for a great event to suppress the whole territory of South Korea by mobilizing all physical means and forces including nuclear forces in contingency", Kim said.

In 2023, the North successfully launched a reconnaissance satellite, after receiving what Seoul claimed was help from Russia in exchange for arms transfers for Ukraine.



PHOTO: AFP

This undated photo provided by the North Korean government shows the testing of new solid-fuel engines designed for intermediate-range ballistic missiles in North Korea.

Israel lays out post-war Gaza plan

AFP
Gaza Strip, Jan. 5

Israel's defence minister has laid out for the first time preliminary plans for the post-war administration of Gaza, saying neither Israel nor Hamas will rule the Palestinian territory after hostilities there conclude.

The plan for the "day after" the war was unveiled Thursday night on the eve of a trip to the region by US Secretary of State Antony Blinken, who is heading back to the Middle East for the fourth time since a Hamas attack on October 7 triggered the war in Gaza.

Questions over the future of the territory have been front of mind for many as calls mount for a ceasefire, with civilian deaths soaring and the UN warning of a humanitarian crisis that has left hundreds of thousands displaced and facing famine and disease.

An outline of the post-war plan by Defence Minister Yoav Gallant, shared with the press ahead of its submission to the country's war cabinet, said "Hamas will not govern Gaza, (and) Israel will not govern Gaza's civilians.

"Gaza residents are Palestinian, therefore Palestinian bodies will be in charge, with the condition that there will be no hostile actions or threats against the State of Israel," it added.

Under the plan, which has not yet been adopted, Israel's war in the territory will continue until it has secured the return of the hostages taken on October 7 and dismantled Hamas's "military and governing capabilities".

After that, the outline says, a new phase will begin during which local Palestinian bodies will assume the territory's governance.



PHOTO: AFP

Smoke rises during Israeli strikes in Khan Younis in the southern Gaza Strip on January 4, 2024.

Israel launched its campaign to destroy Hamas after the group's bloody October 7 attack, which resulted in the deaths of around 1,140 people, most of them civilians, according to an AFP tally based on official Israeli figures.

The militants also took around 250 hostages, 132 of whom remain in captivity, according to Israel.

The military's relentless bombardment and ground invasion have reduced swathes of Gaza to rubble and claimed at least 22,438 lives, according to the territory's Hamas-run health ministry.

'No water, no electricity, no food'

On Thursday the army reported more strikes in and around Gaza City, now a largely devastated urban combat zone, and Khan Yunis, the biggest city in the territory's south.

The army said it had killed Hamas fighters around Khan Yunis, struck "terrorist infrastructure" in the area and hit militants attempting to "place an explosive device near soldiers".

It also said that an air strike in northern Gaza had killed the chief of operational staff for Islamic Jihad, a Palestinian militant group fighting alongside Hamas.

Families in Gaza search desperately for food, water

AP
Gaza Strip, Jan. 5

Stranded in a corner of southern Gaza, members of the Abu Jarad family are clinging to a strict survival routine.

They fled their comfortable three-bedroom home in northern Gaza after the Israel-Hamas war broke out nearly three months ago. The 10-person family now squeezes into a 16-square meter tent on a garbage-strewn sandy plot, part of a sprawling encampment of displaced Palestinians.

Every family member is assigned daily tasks, from collecting twigs to build a fire for cooking, to scouring the city's markets for vegetables. But their best efforts can't mask their desperation. At night "dogs are hovering over the tents," said Awatif Abu Jarad, an older member of the family. "We are living like dogs!"

Palestinians seeking refuge in southern Gaza say every day has become a struggle to find food, water, medicine and working bathrooms. All the while, they live in fear of Israeli airstrikes and the growing threat of illnesses.

Israel's bombardment and ground invasion of Gaza, now in its 13th week, have pushed almost all Palestinians toward the southern city of Rafah along the Egyptian border. The area had a prewar population of around 280,000, a figure that has bulged to over 1 million in recent days, according to the U.N. agency for Palestinian refugees.

Rafah's apartment blocks are crammed with people, often extended families who have opened their doors to displaced relatives. West of the city, thousands of nylon tents have sprung up. Thousands more people are sleeping in the open, despite the cool and often rainy winter weather.

Most of northern Gaza is now under the control of the Israeli army, which early in the war urged Palestinians to evacuate to the south. As the war progressed, more evacuation orders were issued for areas in the south, forcing Palestinian civilians to crowd into ever smaller spaces, including Rafah and a nearby sliver of land called Muwasi. Even these purportedly safe spaces are often hit by airstrikes and shelling.

The war broke out on Oct. 7 after Hamas militants stormed into southern Israel, killing about 1,200 people and abducting 240 others.



PHOTO: AP

Members of the Abu Jarad family, who were displaced by the Israeli bombardment of the Gaza Strip, eat breakfast at a makeshift tent camp in the Muwasi area, southern Gaza, Monday, Jan. 1, 2024

Iowa teenager kills sixth grader

AP
Des Moines, Jan. 5

A 17-year-old opened fire at a small-town Iowa high school on the first day of school after the winter break, killing a sixth-grader and wounding five others as students barricaded in offices and fled in panic.

The suspect, a student at the school in Perry, died of what investigators believe is a self-inflicted gunshot wound, and at least one of the victims is a school administrator, a law enforcement official told The Associated Press. The official was not authorised to publicly discuss details of the investigation and spoke to The AP on condition of anonymity.

Perry has about 8,000 residents and is about 40 miles (64 kilometres) northwest of Des Moines, on the edge of the state capital's metropolitan area. It is home to a large pork-processing plant, and low-slung, single story homes spread among trees now shorn of their leaves by winter. The high school and middle school are connected, sitting on the east edge of town.

Perry High School senior Ava Augustus said she was in a counselor's office, waiting for hers to arrive, when she heard three shots. She and other people barricaded the door, preparing to throw things if necessary, with a window being too small for an escape.

"And then we hear 'He's down. You can go out,'" Augustus said through tears. "And I run and you can just see glass everywhere, blood on the floor. I get to my car and they're taking a girl out of the auditorium who had been shot in her leg."

Three gunshot victims were taken by ambulance to Iowa Methodist Medical Center in Des Moines, a spokesperson for its health system said. Some other patients were transported to a second hospital in Des Moines, a spokesperson for MercyOne Des Moines Medical Center confirmed, declining to comment on the number of patients or their statuses.

Vigils were planned Thursday evening at a park and a local church. A post on the high school's Facebook page said it would be closed Friday, with counseling services planned at the public library Friday and Saturday.

In Washington, US Attorney General Merrick Garland was briefed on the shooting. FBI agents from the Omaha-Des Moines office are assisting with the investigation led by the Iowa Division of Criminal Investigation.

The shooting occurred in the backdrop of Iowa's first-in-the-nation presidential caucuses. GOP candidate Vivek Ramaswamy had a campaign event scheduled in Perry at 9 a.m. about 1 1/2 miles from the high school but canceled it to have a prayer and intimate discussion with area residents.

Two companies to attempt first US moon landings since Apollo missions

AP
Cape Canaveral, Fla., Jan. 5

China and India scored moon landings, while Russia, Japan and Israel ended up in the lunar trash heap.

Now two private companies are hustling to get the U.S. back in the game, more than five decades after the Apollo program ended.

It's part of a NASA-supported effort to kick-start commercial moon deliveries, as the space agency focuses on getting astronauts back there. "They're scouts going to the moon ahead of us," said NASA Administrator Bill Nelson.

Pittsburgh's Astrobotic Technology is up first with a planned liftoff of a lander Monday aboard a brand new rocket, United Launch Alliance's Vulcan. Houston's Intuitive Machines aims to launch a lander in mid-February, hopping a flight with SpaceX.

Then there's Japan, which will attempt to land in two weeks. The Japanese Space Agency's lander with two toy-size rovers had a big head start, sharing a September launch with an X-ray telescope that stayed behind in orbit around Earth.

If successful, Japan will become the fifth country to pull off a lunar landing. Russia and the U.S. did it repeatedly in the 1960s and 70s. China has landed three times in the past decade — including on the moon's far side — and is returning to the far side later this year to bring back lunar samples. And just last summer, India did it. Only the U.S. has put astronauts on the moon.

Landing without wrecking is no easy feat. There's hardly any atmosphere to slow spacecraft, and parachutes obviously won't work. That means a lander must descend using thrusters, while navigating past treacherous cliffs and craters.

A Japanese millionaire's company, ispace, saw its lander smash into the moon last April, followed by Russia's crash landing in August. India triumphed a few days later near the south polar region; it was the country's second try after crashing in 2019. An Israeli nonprofit also slammed into the moon in 2019.

The United States has not attempted a moon landing since Apollo 17's Gene Cernan and Harrison Schmitt, the last of 12 moonwalkers, explored the gray, dusty surface in December 1972. Mars beckoned and the moon receded in NASA's rearview mirror, as the space race between the U.S. and the Soviet Union came to a close. The U.S. followed with a handful or two of lunar satellites, but no controlled landers — until now.

Not only are Astrobotic and Intuitive Machines looking to end America's moon-landing drought, they're vying for bragging rights as the first private entity to land — gently — on the moon.

Despite its later start, Intuitive Machines has a faster, more direct shot and should land within a week of liftoff. It will take Astrobotic two weeks just to get to the moon and another month in lunar orbit, before a landing is attempted on Feb. 23. If there are rocket delays, which already have stalled both missions, either company could wind up there first.

"It's going to be a wild, wild ride," promised Astrobotic's chief executive John Thornton. His counterpart at Intuitive Machines, Steve Altemus, said the space race is "more about the geopolitics, where China is going, where the rest of the world's going." That said, "We sure would like to be first."

The two companies have been nose to nose since receiving nearly $80 million each in 2019 under a NASA program to develop lunar delivery services. Fourteen companies are now under contract by NASA.

Astrobotic's four-legged, 6-foot-tall (1.9-meter-tall) lander, named Peregrine after the fastest bird, a falcon, will carry 20 research packages to the moon for seven countries, including five for NASA and a shoebox-sized rover for Carnegie Mellon University. Peregrine will aim for the mid-latitudes' Sinus Viscositatis, or Bay of Stickiness, named after the long-ago silica magma that formed the nearby Gruithuisen Domes.



PHOTO: AP

This photo provided by Astrobotic Technology shows the Peregrine lunar lander at the company's facility in Pittsburgh in October 2023.

PRISM

Unusual piglet born

Texas: The San Antonio Zoo in Texas announced its first birth of a babirusa, a species of tusked pig native to the tropical forests of Indonesia.

The zoo said first-time parents Sula and Kreacher welcomed the baby on New Year's Day.

Babirusas, the zoo said in a Facebook post, are known for their "distinctive curved tusks and unique appearance," and are unusual for pigs because they have only one or two piglets at a time.

The animals are listed as vulnerable on the IUCN Red List of Threatened Species.

"We are thrilled to welcome this baby to our family -- the first-ever babirusa birth at San Antonio Zoo," Tim Morrow, president and CEO of the San Antonio Zoo, said in the birth announcement.

Performer's Slinky skills create record

China: A Chinese performer created a new Guinness World Records category with his Slinky skills when he used the spring-like toy to surround 41 glass bottles in 1 minute.

Wu Wuqiang, a Guangdong resident who has been creating his own Slinky manipulation tricks since 2009, brought his skills to the set of Italian TV series Le Show dei Record.

The show saw Wu use his Slinky to individually surround 41 bottles in 1 minute, returning the toy to his hands after each bottle.

The feat led Guinness World Records to make him the first title-holder for the most glass bottles trapped with a Slinky in 1 minute.

(AP)

TODAY IN HISTORY

1355 – Charles IV of Bohemia is crowned with the Iron Crown of Lombardy as King of Italy in Milan.
1449 – Constantine XI is crowned Byzantine Emperor at Mystras.
1661 – English Restoration: The Fifth Monarchists unsuccessfully attempt to seize control of London, England. The revolt is suppressed after a few days.
1893 – The Washington National Cathedral is chartered by Congress. [20] The charter is signed by President Benjamin Harrison.
1912 – New Mexico is admitted to the Union as the 47th U.S. state.
1912 – German geophysicist Alfred Wegener first presents his theory of continental drift.
1950 – The United Kingdom recognizes the People's Republic of China. [31] The Republic of China severs diplomatic relations with the UK in response.
1951 – Korean War: Beginning of the Ganghwa massacre, in the course of which an estimated 200–1,300 South Korean communist sympathizers are slaughtered.

SARLAHI CLAMPS CURFEW AFTER A MAN DIES IN CLASH

RSS
Malangawa, Jan. 5

Sarlahi district has clamped a curfew to tame untoward situation after a person dies in a clash erupted over a dispute on a primary health centre at Barahathawa.

As the dispute turned into a demonstration, Jay Shankar Saha, 30, from Barahathawa lost his life.

Police had resorted to blank firing and tear gas shells to contain the situation where demonstrators pelted stones on a residence of Barahathawa municipality mayor, Kalpana Katuwal, and municipality office.

In view of the deteriorating situation and to maintain peace and security, the District Administration Office imposed curfew from 5:30pm till 8:00am tomorrow.

Various political parties as Nepali Congress, Janata Samajbadi Party Nepal, Bahujan, and Janamat Party demonstrated for the enforcement of municipality decision to hand over primary health centre of Barahathawa-6 to the Madhes Province government for its upgrading.

Although the municipality's meeting had made such decision earlier, it later retracted from it, leading to parties' ire.

The meeting decided to hand over the primary health centre to province government to upgrade it as a 50 bed hospital. The political representatives and cadres disapproved the withdrawal of decision which ultimately caused the violent demonstration. Most of the office bearers including Mayor Katuwal withdrew the decision.

TAPLEJUNG'S PATHIBHARA AREA RECEIVES SNOWFALL

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Taplejung, Jan. 5

Pathibhara area, a pilgrimage site in Taplejung district, received snowfall for the second time this season on Thursday.

Rajendra Mahat, a local hotelier in the upper foothills of the Pathibhara area, reported widespread snowfall in the region. He said that there was also snowfall in the lowland area.

Mahat, who is also an employee at the Pathibhara Area Development Committee, said that there might be more snowfall due to the changing weather. The area is still receiving snow, he said.

Residents of the lowland areas informed that after the snowfall, they were feeling extremely cold.

Likewise, locals have predicted that there might be additional snowfall in the high Himalayan areas of the district.

They speculated that the snowfall could have begun after the high mountain ranges were covered by fog.

Snowfall occurred in the district for the first time two months ago. Conversely, farmers in the district were concerned because, despite halfway through the winter season, there was a shortage of both rain and snow.

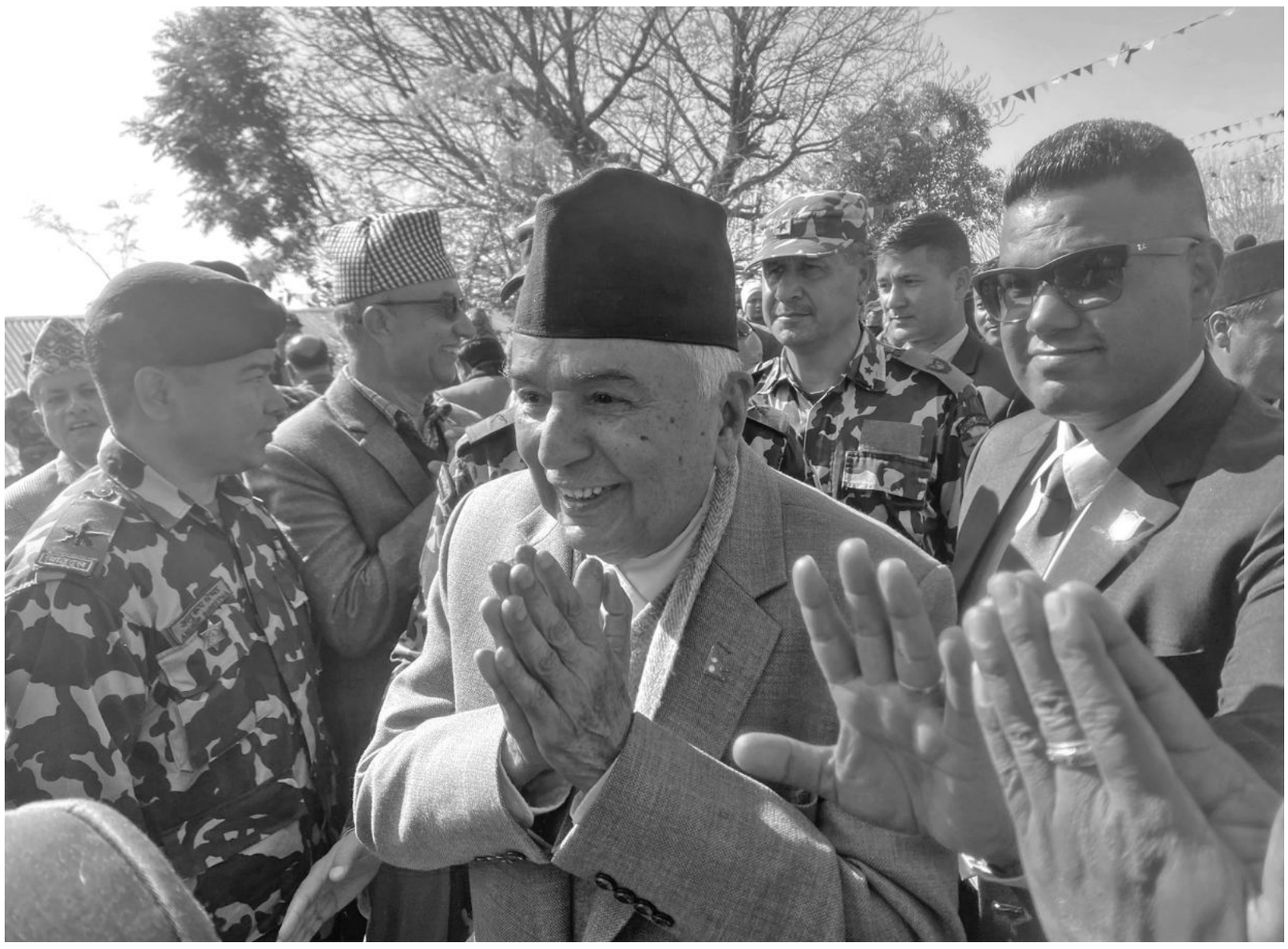


PHOTO: AMAR RAJ NAHARKI/TRN

President Ramchandra Paudel being welcomed in Tanahun district on Friday.

First province-level Agri-Mechinery Exhibition kicks off

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Pokhara, Jan. 5

The first province-level Agri-Mechinery Exhibition 2080 kicked off at Pokhara Exhibition Centre, Nayabazaar, on Friday.

The three-day expo of the agricultural machinery, organised by Nepal Agricultural Machinery Entrepreneurs Association (NAMEA), features more than 70 stalls of 60 companies involved in production, sales, maintenance, training and application of agricultural machineries and equipment.

Speaking at the inaugural programme of the expo, Minister for Agriculture and Land Management of Gandaki Province Mahendra Dhoj GC said that there was no harmony between the situation and policy.

"Demands of farmers and entrepreneurs and policy implementation don't match. Farmers are being displaced from farming and youth have not been attracted to it," he said.

Minister GC stated that since there was a greater realisation of the need to make the production and processing more competitive, technology should be promoted in food production and supply as well as in processing

According to him, the grants on agriculture are highly politicised and support is being provided to party cadres or henchmen.

He questioned on the proper utilisation and effectiveness of machines distributed by the various levels of the governments and suggested that there should be a policy provision as well as institutions for the maintenance of the machines distributed by the government and other agencies including the non-government organisations.

Minister GC assured the farmers and entrepreneurs of the sector that the upcoming provincial periodic plan would accord top priority to agriculture with an aim to attracting youth to agriculture and making them stay in the profession.

Krishna Sharma, President of NAMEA, said that promoting domestic products and industries in agriculture sector was the primary objective of the exhibition and it aimed at making interventions on the use of machineries in agriculture.

However, there is no policy stability while implementation of existing policies is also poor, he said while emphasising the need for more investment in the sector for the modernisation and advancement of agriculture.

"We need to work to reduce the cost of production which can be achieved only through the use and promotion of technology," he said.

According to him, the government only distributes the equipment but there was no provision and system to train farmers and entrepreneurs in maintaining them.

Hemraj Dhakal, Vice-President of the Federation of Nepalese Chambers of Commerce and Industry (FNCCI), said that real farmers should have easy access to concessional loans and government grants.

"It is not fair that only 4 per cent national budget is allocated to the sector that employs about two-thirds of the population and has one-fourth contribution to the national GDP," he said.

Dhakal urged the governments of all levels to allocate 10 per cent of their annual budget to agriculture as it was a sector with high potential along with tourism and Information Technology.

"Mechanisation should be promoted at all sectors of agriculture. Private sector associations should also give priority to agriculture. Facility for the repairing of agricultural tools should be established across the country," he said.

Likewise, Sahadev Prasad Humagain, Secretary of Agriculture and Land Manahement Ministry of Gandaki Province, said that there was a challenge to stop youth drain from agriculture.

According to him, reducing production cost, easy availability of inputs and machines, irrigation facility, and access to markets should be the priority of government and private sector for the development of this sector.

Dr. Hari Bahadur KC, Director General of the Department of Agriculture, said that Agricultural Mechanisation Promotion Policy was in implementation but there was a lot to do in agriculture sector.

We should also discuss about the favourable custom duties on agricultural products and raw materials, he maintained.

Similarly, Arjun Prasad Luintel, General Secretary of NAMIA, pointed to the need to establish agriculture and related business as a profitable venture.

"Mechanisation and modernisation have an important role to play in this. All stakeholders including policymakers, science bodies, and executive agencies should collaborate to achieve this target," he said.

According to Bashudev Regmi, Director General of the Agricultural Development Directorate of Gandaki, reducing cost of production in agriculture should be the focus in coming days.

He also said that machines are required as per the topography, and there is a need to promote and make available women-friendly machines.

He said that this expo will help in promoting local food and positioning market at a greater market place.

Sharada Baral, President of Women Entrepreneurs Association of Nepal, Kaski, said that many women farmers still don't have access to the financial support programmes.

Chitra Nath Poudel, Farmers' representative, said that women have high involvement in agriculture but they are not visible. "They should come forward to voice their demands and concerns," he said.

VOTER LIST FOR NA POLL MADE PUBLIC IN BAGMATI PROVINCE

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Makawanpur, Jan. 5

An all-party meeting held in Hetauda on Friday decided to conduct the upcoming National Assembly Election peacefully.

The meeting held at the district administration office in Makawanpur decided to ensure that the upcoming NA election scheduled for January 25 would be conducted peacefully.

Tara Prasad Acharya, Acting Election Officer at the Provincial Election Office of Bagmati Province, informed about the preparations being made to hold the election in the meeting. He also said that the time to be provided to the political parties for candidate nomination was discussed and decided.

According to him, it has been decided that parties will nominate candidates for the NA member election based on their party registration.

Each party has been allocated half an hour for the nomination of National Assembly members. The scheduled date for this process is January 8, with the CPN-UML commencing the nominations at 10:30 am.

Similarly, the Nepali Congress will be allotted time at 11:00 am, followed by the CPN (Maoist Centre) at 11:30 am. After these initial nominations, other parties will proceed to nominate their candidates.



Meanwhile, according to the National Assembly member election programme, the voter list was published on Friday.

Acharya said that the list of 337 voters was published asking the voters to make any complaint against the list, but no complaint was received against any of the voters included in the list.

In the Bagmati Province Assembly, there are 110 members while the 119 local levels have 237 chiefs and deputy chiefs in total.

The post of the deputy chief of Gaurishankar Rural Municipality in Dolakha has remained vacant, according to the election office of Hetauda.

Additionally, the Election Commission of Nepal had appointed Justice Mahendra Bahadur Karki of the Makawanpur District Court as the Election Officer for the National Assembly member elections, effective from Monday.

Following Karki's acknowledgement of his inability to assume the role of Election Officer, Makwanpur District Judge Shri Prasad Sanjel was appointed as the new Election Officer.

A polling station has been fixed at the technical school building of Bhutandevi Secondary School located in Hetauda-4.

Nepal has no...

Dr. Yogendra Bahadur Gurung, head of the Population Studies Department, said that the authorities needs to design its policy and programmes according to demographic trends, but currently, political parties are designing it according to their choice randomly. For instance, the nation is presently constructing schools without considering demographic trends. However, in the coming years, these establishments might become unnecessary due to the impact of declining birth rates.

Dr. Kamala Devi Lamichhane, lecturer at the Department, said now parents are not discriminating against their children by sex after their birth but it is found in the census that they did discriminate before their birth.

The census report reveals a disparity with 100 girls born for every 114 boys, different from the universal ratio of 100 girls to 105 boys. Such gender imbalances could lead to future challenges.

Hence, the nation needs proficient demographers to analyse and communicate this information to stakeholders to plan and work according to the requirements. However, the Department has been facing a shortage of students to pursue population studies, Gurung said. "Therefore, the Department has been launching various schemes to lure students," he said.

President Paudel expresses concern...

Saying that Jitgadhi is a spectacular place of national integrity and identity, President Paudel expressed happiness over the advancement of a plan to develop Jitgadhi as a tourism center.

He expressed pleasure for the Nepal Army working in tandem with the three-tiers of government as per the master plan of Jitgadhi reconstruction.

The Head of the State underlined the need to undertake research and study on Nepal-British war in Jitgahdhi fort and promote it as a tourism center.

He urged Butwal sub-metropolis, province and federal governments to pay attention to the preservation and promotion of such places having historical and strategic importance.

The Nepal Army has been safeguarding the country's independence, sovereignty, territorial integrity and national unity, he mentioned. "Nepal Army has been protecting the country and the people, conserving the nature, building the nation, managing disasters and helping citizens in need", the President noted.

Indian Foreign Minister...

Agreements inked between the two countries include the implementation of High Impact Community Development Projects (HICDPs) in Nepal with an increased budget of up to Rs. 200 million from earlier Rs. 50 million, the Long Term Power Trade to facilitate in increasing the export of power from Nepal to India to 10,000 MW within a decade, and launching Munal Satellite developed by Nepal Academy of Science and Technology (NAST).

The power trade agreement was signed between the energy ministries of Nepal and India, while agreement on HICDP was signed by Nepal's Finance Secretary, Dr. Krishna Hari Pushkar, and Indian Ambassador to Nepal, Naveen Srivastava. Likewise, the agreement on the launching of satellite was signed between NewSpace India Limited and NAST.

During the meeting on Thursday, a MoU for Co-operation in the Renewable Energy Development between Nepal Electricity Authority (NEA) and NTPC Limited was also signed.

The two foreign ministers also jointly inaugurated virtually three 132 kV cross-border transmission lines between India and Nepal - the second circuit of Raxaul-Parwanipur line, the second circuit of Kataiya-Kusaha line, and the New Nautanwa-Mainhiya line. These infrastructures are supposed to help in promoting enhanced power trade between the two countries.

Similarly, Nepal Electricity Authority and NTPC Limited of India signed a MoU for cooperation in renewable energy development.

Similarly, the fifth tranche of the post Jajarkot-earthquake relief supply provided by the Government of India was also handed over to Nepal during the meeting. In addition, India will provide financial assistance package of Rs. 10 billion for post Jajarkot-earthquake reconstruction.

According to the MEA of India, the relief package consists of 200 prefabricated houses, 1200 blankets, 150 tents and 2000 sleeping bags for the earthquake affected people in Nepal. Out of the 200 prefabricated houses, 20 were handed over on Thursday and the remaining shall be handed over in various tranches over the next few weeks, the MEA said in a statement.

Minister Dr. Jaishankar also paid courtesy calls on President of Nepal, Ramchandra Paudel, Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda', former prime minister and President of the Nepali Congress, Sher Bahadur Deuba, and former PM and Chair of CPN-UML, KP Sharma Oli.

He also met former PM and Chair of CPN (Unified Socialist), Madhav Kumar Nepal, and leaders of other political parties, visited Cricket Association of Nepal.

Sri Lanka declares moratorium on research ships for a year

AP
Colombo, Jan. 5

Sri Lanka has declared a moratorium on foreign research ships entering its waters for a year amid concerns from India over Chinese research vessels docking in its neighborhood.

Though the moratorium comes ostensibly for capacity building it is seen as a reaction to growing concerns in India.

Foreign Ministry spokesman Niluka Kadurugamuwa told The Associated Press on Friday that the moratorium relates to all countries and will allow local researchers to build capacity be on a par with their foreign counterparts in joint researches.

Chinese ships have docked in Colombo in recent years for research based on agreements between agencies in China and Sri Lanka.

Last October, Chinese research ship Shi Yan 6 docked in Colombo port for several days, while in 2022 the navy vessel Yuan Wang 5 docked at Hambantota in southern Sri Lanka. There were fears in India that these vessels could be used to monitor the region.

China has been trying to expand its influence in Sri Lanka, which is located on one of the world's busiest shipping routes in what India considers part of its strategic backyard.

Beijing was once widely seen as having an upper hand with its free-flowing loans and infrastructure investments. But Sri Lanka's economic collapse in 2022 provided an opportunity for India as New Delhi stepped in with massive financial and material assistance.

Both countries recently agreed on terms with Sri Lanka separately for restructuring its debt, which enabled the disbursement of a second installment of a $2.9 billion package from the International Monetary Fund aimed at helping the island nation out of its dire economic crisis.

Sri Lanka declared bankruptcy in April 2022 with more than $83 billion of debt, more than half owed to foreign creditors. China accounts for about 10% of Sri Lanka's loans, trailing Japan and the Asian Development Bank.

Sri Lanka borrowed heavily from China over the past decade for infrastructure projects including a seaport, airport and a city being built on reclaimed land. The projects failed to earn enough revenue to pay for the loans, and in 2017, Sri Lanka leased the seaport in Hambantota to China.

Untold Story of Yasodhara

BY RENUKA DHAKAL
Kathmandu, Jan. 5





'Gulaf' (The Rose) is currently being staged at Mandala Theatre in Thapa Gaun, Kathmandu, exploring the various dimensions of Yasodhara's emotional, mental and physical hardships following Siddhartha Gautama's sudden departure from the palace.

Siddhartha Gautama, who is now revered as Lord Gautam Buddha, is venerated by billions worldwide as the epitome of peace and harmony.

Despite this widespread recognition, Yasodhara, His wife, remains less known to many, and her story is often overlooked.

She experienced profound upheaval when Siddhartha Gautama departed from her life.

Yasodhara's dreams and aspirations were shattered when Siddhartha Gautama left the palace to seek enlightenment.

During this crucial familial period, a wife was separated from her husband, and a son was left bereft of the love and care of his father.

However, as the saying goes, time heals everything. Yasodhara also followed a celibate life over time, finding happiness for both her physical and spiritual well-being.

The play 'Gulaf', directed by Ramhari Dhakal, revolves around the emotional state of Yasodhara with Siddhartha and without Siddhartha and how she seeks solace for her soul.

Two actors, Diya Maskey and Sarita Sah, are seen on the stage at the centre surrounded by the audience inside the curtains.

Both actors, adorning the same attire, watch each other, following the same expression and gesture with full compassion at first.

But as the play further develops, the two of them start fighting and struggling. The two characters represent the physical form and soul form of Yasodhara and the action of Yasodhara's turmoil.

The characters show the physical and mental condition of Yasodhara before Siddhartha left the palace.

Yasodhara was happy and living a blissful life with her husband Siddhartha, but her happiness shattered after Siddhartha left her.

The play is based on the physical theatre genre, and the story is narrated through expression and gesture.

Except for the whispering or gossiping when Siddhartha left the palace, the whole play is non-verbally executed.

Both actors have made the play watchable for 50 minutes with fine expressions and gestures

Director Dhakal, known for his experimental works, has previously done sensory theatre like 'inside\outside' and 'Chakra'.

Breaking from the conventional theatrical practice where artists perform in front of the audience while audiences watch from the back, Dhakal has arranged the stage at the centre, creating an immersive experience where the audience surrounds the artists.

The play will be staged until Sunday and will subsequently embark on a tour of various European cities.

Neo-Nazi podcasters sent to prison on terror charges for targeting Prince Harry and his young son

AP
London, Jan. 5



A neo-Nazi podcaster who called for the deaths of Prince Harry and his young son received a prison sentence Thursday along with his co-host Thursday. The sentencing judge in London called the duo "dedicated and unapologetic white supremacists" who encouraged terrorism.

Christopher Gibbons and Tyrone Patten-Walsh espoused racist, antisemitic, Islamophobic, homophobic and misogynistic views and encouraged listeners of their "Lone Wolf Radio" podcast to commit violent acts against ethnic minorities, authorities said.

Using aliases on their show, the pair said "the white race was likely to be 'genocided' unless steps were taken to fight back." They approved of a day when so-called race traitors would be hanged, particularly those in interracial relationships. Prince Harry's wife, Meghan, is biracial.

On one episode, Gibbons said the Duke of Sussex should be "prosecuted and judicially killed for treason" and called Harry's son, Archie, who is now 4, a "creature" that "should be put down."

Gibbons, 40, was sentenced to eight years in prison, the Metropolitan Police said. Patten-Walsh, 34, was given a 7-year term. Both will be on the equivalent of probation for three years after their release.

"The evidence demonstrates that you desire to live in a world dominated by white people purely for white people. Your distorted thinking is that the white race has ceded too much influence to Blacks and Asians, to Jews and Muslims, to gays, to white liberals and to white people in mixed-race relationships," Judge Peter Lodder said.

While Patten-Walsh and Gibbons were entitled to hold their beliefs — regardless of being "as preposterous as they are offensive to a civilized society" — Lodder said they had gone too far.

The London men started "Lone Wolf Radio," which had 128 subscribers and around 9,000 views of its 21 episodes in June 2020.

The two celebrated right-wing extremists who carried out mass murders in Norway, Christchurch, New Zealand and Charleston, South Carolina. They also posted images of a Nazi executing a Jewish man at the edge of a pit of corpses and Nelson Mandela being lynched.

A Kingston Crown Court jury convicted them in July of eight counts of encouraging terrorism.

Gibbons was also convicted of two counts of disseminating terrorist documents through his online neo-Nazi "radicalization" library that had more than 2,000 subscribers, authorities said.

Cmdr. Dominic Murphy, who heads the Met's counter terrorism unit, said the material they disseminated "is exactly the kind that has the potential to draw vulnerable people — particularly young people — into terrorism."

Community schools in Kamal to hire dance instructors

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Jhapa, Jan. 5



Kamal Rural Municipality in Jhapa is all set to hire Ghumti dance instructors for its community schools.

The rural municipality has initiated the required procedures and completed the final preparations to appoint teachers for this purpose.

Ward chairman Hukum Singh Rai said that the decision aimed at boosting the interest of community school students in dance, as there is a growing enthusiasm among children for this art form.

Most of the private schools have been hiring dance instructors recently, but this is not the case in community schools, said Rai.

Rai emphasised the municipality's commitment to enhancing extracurricular activities, particularly dance, in community schools.

He said that Ghumti trainers will be deployed to teach in these schools.

Similarly, Rajkumar Shakya, the chief administrative officer of the Kamal Rural Municipality, said that the Koshi Province Chief Minister's Office had given consent to declare Kamal Rural Municipality as a child-friendly local level.

After fulfilling all the necessary criteria, the consent of the Chief Minister's Office was sought, he added.

Comic book on K-pop group BTS charts their rise to stardom and military service

REUTERS
New York, Jan. 5



A new comic book chronicles the rise to stardom of South Korea's K-pop music sensation BTS and their recent transition to military service.

TidalWave Comics has added the 22-page book to its FAME series, which uses the comic medium to shine a light on musical acts.

Since their 2013 debut, BTS have become a worldwide sensation with their upbeat hits and social campaigns aimed at empowering youth.

The glossy chronicles how the seven singers became famous - and their switch from pop stars to soldiers.

All able-bodied men in South Korea aged between 18 and 28 must serve in the military for between 18 and 21 months as part of efforts to defend against nuclear-armed North Korea.

Some have won exemptions or served shorter terms, including Olympic medalists and prize-winning classical musicians. Some lawmakers had called for BTS to be exempt.

But in December 2022 the eldest member Jin joined the army, and the others followed, with the final three beginning their duty last month. Fans have pledged to wait until 2025 for them to perform as a group again.

The book will be released in both print and digital formats and soft and hardcovers on Jan. 10.

HOROSCOPE

tarot.com

ARIES: Authority figures may cause you to doubt yourself. You could notice your superiors flourishing in their career fields in a way that you hope you will be doing someday, but at present.

TAURUS: Your nervous energy might surge at any moment. It'll be difficult to calm any strained nerves when you're faced with uncertain situations and people who won't communicate or connect with you.

GEMINI: You may feel like a small fish in a big pond. Previously, you likely felt confident in yourself and your skills, but once you step out into the big time or begin being held to higher standards.

CANCER: Resisting authority probably isn't productive at the moment. Someone may give you instructions that you don't feel are efficient, and you're probably used to doing things your way in your domain.

LEO: Current discomfort may actually be a good sign. Even if you already have a routine or certain style that you like to adhere to, today the universe is challenging you to step out of your usual mode.

VIRGO: Worries and risks are walking hand in hand. You may feel a familiar FOMO, and to eliminate it, you might be tempted to splurge on expensive frivolities that seem as though they'll prove that you're with the in-crowd.

LIBRA: Your relationships could hurt your feelings with ongoing demands. This doesn't have to be a romantic relationship. It can apply to friends, coworkers, or family.

SCORPIO: You might feel lost today. Especially when it comes to those who don't understand you or are even actively working against you, it's important to play your cards close to the chest.

SAGITTARIUS: Present events probably feel more dramatic than they actually are. You might experience drama more intensely than those around you, as the statements and actions could hit home with you in a way.

CAPRICORN: Heightened emotions might end up ruling your day. You're at risk of intense mood swings, where you'll be having the time of your life one moment, and the next.

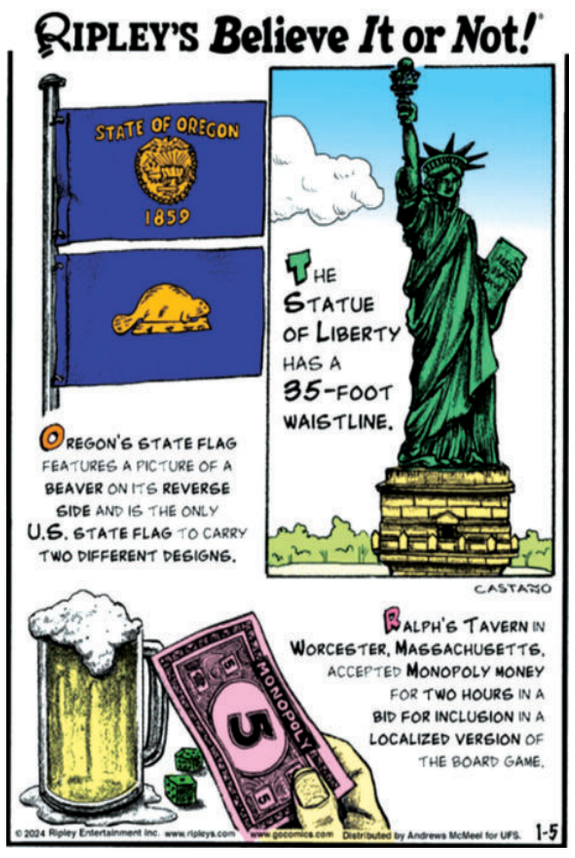
AQUARIUS: Your support system might need your support. You may normally rely on these people to have your back, but when they're calling out for help, you could be asked to put other obligations on hold.

PISCES: Any stable ground likely feels like a blessing in life's current uncertainty. Unfortunately, this may lead you to pursue a truth that isn't quite true, in order to find some confirmation.

CARTOON

gocomics.com





U19 cricket team off to South Africa for World Cup



PHOTO: BIKASH/TRN

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 5

Nepal's men's U19 cricket team was bade farewell on Friday as they left for South Africa to participate in the ICC U19 Men's Cricket World Cup 2024.

A 15-men squad, which was announced Thursday night, was bidden farewell by the Cricket Association of Nepal (CAN).

The World Cup's warm-up matches begin on January 13 while the group stages will kick off on January 19.

The squad list shows two changes compared to the 14-men squad for the U19 Asia Cup held in December 2023. Durgesh Thapa is replacing Hemant Dhami, a fast bowler, as he is unavailable due to an injury. All-rounder Dipak Bohora is also enlisted in the squad.

Dev Khanal is captaining the team which also includes experienced Gulshan Kumar Jha. Arjun Kumal, Aakash Tripathi, Dipak Prasad Dumre, Dipesh Prasad Kandel, Bishal Bikram KC, Subhash Bhandari, Deepak Bohora, Uttam Rangu Thapa Magar, Bipin Rawal, Tilak Raj Bhandari and Akash Chand are the other players in the squad.

At the farewell function, captain Khanal expressed his confidence in getting positive results. "We got a chance to prepare outside for at least a week. We are all happy about it, and I hope good results will come." Khanal said that his team is moving forward by learning from the weaknesses in the Asia Cup. "Playing at the World Cup is everyone's dream, and it was mine too. Whatever happened in the Asia Cup should be set aside, and we should focus on improving our performance in the coming days," said Khanal.

The squad was training under Coach Jagat Tamata, who is also a former chief coach of the national cricket team, before leaving for South Africa.

According to CAN, the team was flying to South Africa one week before the tournament to train at a high-performance camp until January 12.

Nepal will be playing two warm-up matches on January 13 and 16 against Scotland and West Indies respectively.

Of the four groups for 16 teams participating in the World Cup, Nepal is placed in Group D with Pakistan, Afghanistan and New Zealand. Nepal's first group match is against New Zealand on January 21.

Hazlewood has Pakistan reeling after Jamal's 3rd Test heroics

AFP
Sydney, Jan. 5



Josh Hazlewood claimed three wickets in an electrifying over to bowl Australia into a potential winning position over Pakistan in an absorbing third Test in Sydney on Friday.

Paceman Hazlewood ripped through to reduce the tourists from 67 for four to go to the close on the third day at 68 for seven, a lead of 82, on a deteriorating Sydney Cricket Ground pitch.

Pakistan's last genuine hopes of building a challenging target for Australia to chase in the fourth innings hinge on Mohammad Rizwan, who is six not out, and bowling hero Aamer Jamal, who is yet to score. Hazlewood swung the contest, taking 4-9 off five overs, after Australia snared two wickets for just one run in the first eight balls of the second innings to rock the Pakistan top order.

The visitors looked to have the edge after dismissing Australia for 299, to take a first-innings lead of 14, on the back of an inspired 6-69 from Jamal.

In a superb four-wicket spell after tea, Jamal first had Mitchell Marsh caught at mid-off by Shan Masood for 54.

'Over the moon'

Two balls later he had Pat Cummins lbw for a duck and followed up with the dismissals of Nathan Lyon (5) and Hazlewood (0). "I am over the moon. Feeling proud to be representing my country at such a level and performing for them," Jamal said. "This is a wonderful achievement for me.

The stung Australians roared back removing Abdullah Shafique for his second duck of the Test and skipper Shan Masood first ball. Young debutant Saim Ayub, out without scoring in the first innings, showed poise and technique in putting on 56 runs with Babar Azam, before he was lbw to Lyon for 33. It was Lyon's 507th Test wicket.

Azam fell 14 balls later, getting a nick off Travis Head to wicketkeeper Alex Carey for 23. Then Hazlewood struck with his electrifying fifth over, the penultimate one of the day.

Earlier, Marsh continued his rich vein of form in Australia's first innings after scores of 90, 63 not out and 96 in the first two Tests.

Marsh and Alex Carey (38) put on 84 to restore the innings after the loss of Steve Smith, Marnus Labuschagne and Head earlier in the day.

NATIONAL WADO-RYU OPEN KARATE ON JAN. 12

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 5

Nepal Wado-Ryu Karate Do Association is organising the final matches between provincial champions for the 4th National Wado-Ryu Open Karate Championship on January 12 and 13.

The tournament is being held at Basundhara-based Yeti Party Palace. According to the organisers, the winners will be awarded with a cash prize as well. Hari Sharan KC, chief coach and the chairman of the association, said, "No Karate championship has ever provided a cash prize to the players in Nepal to date. We have decided to change the tradition to show that sports can be a source of proper income."

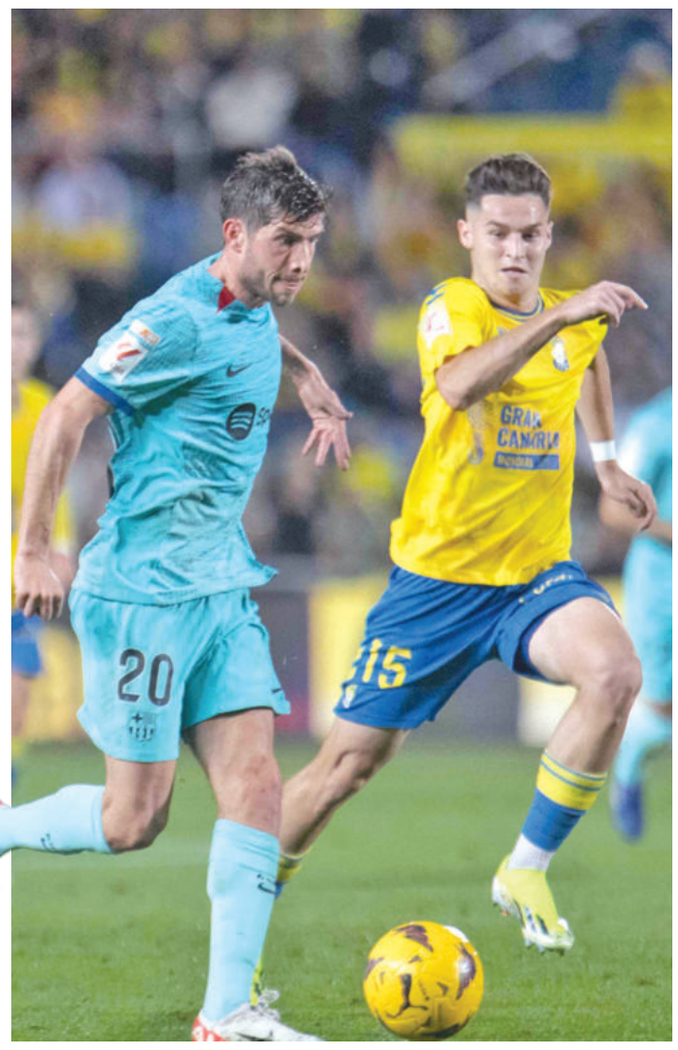
Medallists, best male and female fighters and top three teams will be awarded with cash prizes. The purse of the cash prize has not been decided yet. Organisers informed that every province will be represented by 12 players each who were selected on the basis of provincial-level tournaments.

"Of the 12 players, a boy and a girl will participate in kata separately while five boys and five girls will compete in five different weigh categories," said KC. The weight categories for men's are 50kg, 55kg, 60kg, 65kg and open; the categories for women's are 45kg, 50kg, 55kg, 60kg and open.

The tournament has also insured its players and staffs. An injured individual will receive an insurance amount of up to Rs. 300,000. "In case of death, which is an unprecedented accident, Rs. 700,000 will be provided under the insurance," said KC.

Barca edge Las Palmas with late Gundogan goal

AP
Madrid, Jan. 5



Barcelona needed a penalty kick in stoppage time to win 2-1 at Las Palmas and keep pace with leaders Real Madrid and Girona in the Spanish league on Thursday.

Ilkay Gundogan sent his shot from the penalty spot into the middle of the net three minutes into added time to keep Barcelona within seven points of leaders Madrid and Girona at the halfway point of the season.

It was another poor performance by Barcelona, which ended last year with three setbacks before edging last-place Almeria in a match in which it was booed by its own fans after another lackluster outing.

The hosts loudly complained of the penalty that prompted the decisive goal and a red card to Daley Sinkgraven for an alleged push on Gundogan inside the area.

Munir El Haddadi, a former Barcelona player, had put Las Palmas ahead from close range in the 11th, and Torres equalized in the 55th from inside the area.

Las Palmas, winless in three matches, has not beaten Barcelona in 15 league matches, with five draws and 10 losses.

Sevilla's struggles continued with a 2-0 home loss to Athletic Bilbao, followed by Sergio Ramos getting into a verbal spat with a fan in his post-match interview.

The veteran defender was talking to a television reporter by the sideline when he angrily responded to a fan who was apparently yelling at him from the stands.

It was the fifth defeat in Sevilla's last six matches in all competitions, leaving the traditional club from southern Madrid in 16th place, one point from the relegation zone.

Juventus reach quarterfinals

Juventus overcame an early error and came back from a goal down to rout last-placed Serie A club Salernitana 6-1 on Thursday and reach the Italian Cup quarterfinals.

The Bianconeri will face Frosinone next week.

Juventus, which is two points behind leader Inter Milan in the league, scored six goals for the first time in any competition since beating Sassuolo 7-0 in Serie A in February 2018.

Juventus faces Salernitana again in Serie A on Sunday.

Everton hold on for draw

Everton held on for a 0-0 draw at Crystal Palace in the third round of the FA Cup on Thursday, despite going down to 10 men when Dominic Calvert-Lewin was sent off in the second half. The Premier League teams will meet again in a replay at Goodison Park to determine who advances to the next round.

Palace may regret missing the chance to take advantage after Calvert-Lewin's contentious red card in the 79th minute at Selhurst Park for a foul on Nathanial Clyne.

Everton's away fans were left incensed after VAR invited referee Chris Kavanagh to review what had appeared to be an innocuous challenge. After viewing the sideline monitor, the official opted to send off the England striker.

Martial Artist Siddartha promoting WUMA Kung Fu in Nepal

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 5

Siddartha Lama Tamang, a dedicated martial artist, is on a mission to popularise Kung Fu in Nepal as a means of a healthy lifestyle.

Like all martial arts, Kung Fu aims to develop self-defence skills and encourage a healthy lifestyle. It offers a wide range of physical and mental benefits, from managing stress to strengthening the body. Kung Fu is an effective way to stay fit and it requires little to no equipment.

As the founding secretary and president of the Nepal WUMA Kung Fu Association, affiliated with England's World United Martial Arts (WUMA), Siddartha has been instrumental in this endeavour.

"Nepal WUMA Kung Fu's goal is to play a significant role in addressing chronic health issues faced by people of all ages in Nepal," he says.

The association prioritises Qi-Gong and Tai Chi given their effectiveness in treating various diseases. "Qi-Gong & Tai Chi have proven their effectiveness in combating chronic diseases like hypertension, diabetes, thyroid disorders and other age-related illnesses," says the WUMA Kung Fu chief.

"In the present context, Nepali children are also suffering from anxiety and depression. Adults are also engaged in unhealthy habits and addiction. Practising Qi Gong and Tai Chi, which are traditional Chinese medicine techniques, can help combat these issues," says Siddartha, who is also the national representative for World Tai Chi.

The association provides training to individuals dealing with chronic illnesses and people suffering from depression, and addiction, among others.

Siddartha has a wide-ranging ambition for Kung Fu in Nepal that goes beyond its medicinal use.



He aims to promote the sport's growth in the country. Currently, more than 1500 players train in WUMA Kung Fu, with over fifty coaches and training centres spread across 23 districts. The association plans to develop highly skilled players and coaches by sending them to China and other countries.

Siddartha, who serves as the Asia Director of WMAC Austria, and the Nepal Chapter President of IKFF, China and WUMA UK, has been instrumental in providing international opportunities to Nepali players.

Nepali WUMA Kung Fu practitioners participate every year in various competitions such as the World Championship, European Championship, British Open, and German Open. They not only compete as players but also serve as judges and referees, bringing honour to their nation with their victories.

Siddartha himself has successfully judged several national and international tournaments, including the 14th National Kung Fu Championship-2022 of India and the European Championship 2022 held in England. He also received a lifetime achievement award from the Kung Fu Federation of India for his contributions to the sport.

Siddartha, the double gold medallist at the German Open International Championship 2023, asserts that those practising WUMA Kung Fu can represent the country in various international championships and make a living by teaching Qi-Gong and Tai Chi.

The association is affiliated with the International Kung Fu Federation (IKFF) of China, and as such, Siddartha, the Nepal Chapter president of IKFF, has coordinated to provide scholarships to ten Nepali players annually.

"The main aim of our association is to offer WUMA Kung Fu training to people of all ages, from children to adults and senior citizens. However, our ultimate goal is to introduce Qi-Gong and Tai Chi to every Nepali household, thus helping them improve their physical and mental health," Siddartha emphasizes.

WEATHER

Saturday

Sunrise at 6:56 am, Sunset at 5:23 pm

Forecast for Nepal (Saturday)

Partly cloudy in Koshi Province and Madesh Province along with the hilly regions of Gandaki Province, Lumbini Province and Karnali Province and mainly fair in the rest of the country. Chances of light snowfall at one or two places of the high hilly and mountainous region of Koshi Province and Gandaki Province.

Expected Temp.: 16 - 18°C
Rain Probability: ...%

Friday's Weather Record

Stations	Max. temp. (C)	Min. temp. (C)	Rain (mm)
Dadeldhura	16.4	3.3	0.0
Dipayal	23.6	2.8	0.0
Dhangadi	17.7	10.2	0.0
Birendranagar	23.1	4.8	0.0
Nepalgunj	20.0	12.2	0.0
Jumla	14.5	-6.6	0.0
Ghorahi	21.8	7.6	0.0
Pokhara	20.5	8.0	0.0
Bhairahawa	18.4	9.0	0.0
Simara	24.0	6.5	0.0
Kathmandu	17.5	3.5	0.0
Okhaldhunga	16.6	6.5	0.0
Taplejung	15.5	5.0	0.0
Dhankuta	22.1	7.6	0.0
Biratnagar	25.2	9.2	0.0
Jomsom	9.5	-4.5	0.0*
Dharan	25.0	13.0	0.0*
Lumle	15.6	4.8	0.0*
Janakpur	27.5	9.6	0.0*
Jiri	14.3	-0.7	0.0*

NEPAL RASTRA BANK

FOREIGN EXCHANGE DEPARTMENT

EXCHANGE RATES

January 6, 2024

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
Indian Rupee	100	Rs. 160.00	Rs. 160.15

Open Market Exchange Rates
For the purpose of Nepal Rastra Bank

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
U.S. Dollar	1	Rs. 132.75	Rs. 133.35
Euro	1	Rs. 144.86	Rs. 145.51
Pound Sterling	1	Rs. 167.98	Rs. 168.73
Swiss Franc	1	Rs. 155.61	Rs. 156.31
Australian Dollar	1	Rs. 88.64	Rs. 89.04
Canadian Dollar	1	Rs. 99.27	Rs. 99.72
Singapore Dollar	1	Rs. 99.70	Rs. 100.15
Japanese Yen	10	Rs. 9.14	Rs. 9.18
Chinese Yuan	1	Rs. 18.56	Rs. 18.64
Saudi Arab Riyal	1	Rs. 35.40	Rs. 35.56
Qatari Riyal	1	Rs. 36.41	Rs. 36.58
Thai Bhat	1	Rs. 3.82	Rs. 3.84
UAE Dirham	1	Rs. 36.14	Rs. 36.31
Malaysian Ringgit	1	Rs. 28.52	Rs. 28.65
South Korean Won	100	Rs. 10.07	Rs. 10.12
Swedish Kronar	1	Rs. 12.91	Rs. 12.97
Danish Kronar	1	Rs. 19.42	Rs. 19.51
Hong Kong Dollar	1	Rs. 17.00	Rs. 17.07
Kuwaiti Dinar	1	Rs. 431.52	Rs. 433.48
Bahrain Dinar	1	Rs. 352.12	Rs. 353.71

Note: Under the present system the open market exchange rates quoted by different banks may differ.

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